

72nd BPSC PRELIMS

प्रहार

Test Series

Test- 07

Ancient History

Solution

English



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BPSC PRELIMS TEST - 7 (SOLUTION)

Q 1. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Somapura Mahavihara at Paharpur, built under the Pala ruler Dharmapala in the 8th century CE, represents one of the largest monastic complexes in the subcontinent and is a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- Its defining architectural feature is a massive terraced cruciform (cross-shaped) central shrine rising from a square courtyard surrounded by over 170 cells on all four sides. This cruciform terraced temple plan, with its tiered projecting extensions on each cardinal face, bears a documented structural resemblance to the temple architecture of Southeast Asian Buddhist monuments, most notably the Shiva temple at Prambanan and the broader architectural design of temples in Cambodia and Myanmar.
- Chola Dravidian architecture evolved from an independent southern Agamic tradition.
- Rashtrakuta rock-cut architecture at Ellora followed western Deccan cave traditions with strong Chalukyan precedents
- Chandela Nagara temples at Khajuraho belonged to the north Indian Shikhara tradition, entirely distinct from the Paharpur cruciform plan.

Q 2. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The Harappan economy was not based on coined or metallic money.
 - ✓ There is no archaeological evidence of coins or currency in the Indus Valley Civilisation.
 - ✓ Their trade system operated mainly through barter exchange (direct exchange of goods and services).
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Harappan Civilisation: Extensively used standardised burnt bricks for houses, drainage systems, and urban planning.
 - ✓ Egyptian Civilisation: Used mainly sun-dried mud bricks, not burnt bricks.
 - ✓ Mesopotamian Civilisation: Used burnt bricks, but only in limited regions and specific structures, not as a dominant material like Harappa.

- **Statement 3 is correct:** Archaeological evidence shows Harappan seals discovered in Mesopotamian sites like Ur and Susa (Iranian plateau).

- ✓ These seals indicate trade and cultural contact between the two civilisations.
- ✓ They also suggest:
 - Active long-distance trade networks
 - Possible exchange of goods like beads, textiles, and metals
 - Shared commercial interactions during the Bronze Age

Q 3. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** Iron technology in the Gangetic plains significantly predates Alexander's Macedonian campaigns of 326 BCE by several centuries. The use of iron tools and implements in the middle Gangetic region is associated with the Northern Black Polished Ware cultural phase, dating broadly to around 700-600 BCE. Iron technology developed and spread across the subcontinent through indigenous processes of diffusion and was already well established in Magadha long before any Macedonian contact with the region.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The availability and widespread use of iron ploughshares was a decisive factor in the agricultural expansion of the middle Gangetic plains. The dense tropical forests of the region, particularly the hard-rooted vegetation of the Terai and the alluvial plains, could not be effectively cleared and cultivated with the softer copper or bronze tools of earlier periods. Iron ploughshares made it technologically possible to break and turn the heavy alluvial soil and to systematically clear forested tracts for cultivation, directly enabling the agrarian expansion that underpinned Magadha's economic and political rise.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Magadha did not need to import iron ore from the Deccan. Iron ore was abundantly available in the regions immediately adjacent to the Magadhan heartland, particularly in the Singhbhum

district of modern Jharkhand and the Chota Nagpur plateau, which lie in close geographical proximity to the ancient Magadhan territories of Bihar. This local availability of iron ore was itself one of the structural advantages that gave Magadha a decisive military and agricultural edge over rival Mahajanapadas.

Q 4. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Mahishmati was an important urban center and served as the capital of the southern part of the Avanti kingdom (while Ujjayini was the capital of the northern part).
- Vaishali was the capital of the Vajji Mahajanapada.
- Kausambi was the capital of the Vatsa Mahajanapada.
- Champa was the capital of the Anga Mahajanapada.

Q 5. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Gupta Era was initiated by Chandragupta I and is dated to 319-320 CE. This era, known as the Gupta Samvat, marked the formal proclamation of Gupta imperial authority and became the official calendrical system used in Gupta records and inscriptions.
 - ✓ The initiation of a new era was a significant political act in ancient India, conventionally associated with a ruler's claim to sovereign and independent status, distinguishing Chandragupta I from the subordinate position his predecessors had occupied.
 - ✓ The Gupta Era continued to be used in official records throughout the duration of the dynasty.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Chandragupta I was the first Gupta ruler to assume the grand imperial title of Maharajadhiraja, meaning "king of great kings."
 - ✓ His predecessors, Srigupta and Ghatotkacha, used only the title Maharaja, which denoted regional kingship without any claim to overlordship over other rulers.
 - ✓ The adoption of Maharajadhiraja signalled that Chandragupta I had transcended tributary status and established direct

imperial authority over a substantial territory.

- ✓ His political consolidation was significantly strengthened by his marriage to the Lichchhavi princess Kumaradevi, a strategic matrimonial alliance that brought him prestige, resources, and legitimacy in the Gangetic heartland.
- ✓ Chandragupta I and Kumaradevi are together depicted on a special gold coin series, the Kumaradevi type.
- ✓ The Lichchhavis were one of the most prestigious republican clans of ancient India, and the alliance gave the early Gupta state a foothold in the fertile Gangetic plains centred around Pataliputra and Vaishali.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The defeat of the Shaka Kshatrapas and the annexation of Western India were accomplished by Chandragupta II, not Chandragupta I.
 - ✓ The Western Kshatrapas, also called Shaka Satraps, had controlled Malwa, Gujarat, and Saurashtra for several centuries and represented a formidable regional power.
 - ✓ Chandragupta II defeated the last Western Satrap, Rudrasimha III, and absorbed these territories into the Gupta Empire.
 - ✓ To consolidate his legitimacy over the newly acquired western regions, Chandragupta II issued silver coins modelled closely on the Western Satrap coinage, a deliberate political strategy to ease the transition of power in those areas.
 - ✓ This western conquest gave the Gupta Empire direct access to the lucrative western sea trade routes and ports, significantly enhancing its commercial and economic reach.
 - ✓ Chandragupta I's own territorial achievements were largely confined to the middle Gangetic plains, and he laid the foundation upon which his son Samudragupta and grandson Chandragupta II built a pan-subcontinental empire.

Q 6. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** Banawali, a major Harappan site in present-day Haryana, is

mainly associated with the cultivation of barley and wheat.

- ✓ Archaeological excavations have revealed a considerable quantity of barley at the site.
- ✓ Evidence of rice cultivation in the Harappan civilisation has been found mainly at Lothal and Rangpur, especially during the later phase of the civilisation.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Harappans were among the earliest known people in the world to cultivate cotton.
 - ✓ Cotton textiles formed an important part of their agricultural and trade economy.
 - ✓ Greek writers referred to cotton as “sindon”, a term believed to be derived from Sindh, the region associated with the Indus civilisation.

Q 7. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Paisara is located in the Munger district of Bihar. Paisara is a highly significant Lower Palaeolithic (Acheulean) habitation and factory site. It is particularly famous because excavations here revealed alignments of stone blocks and post-holes, providing rare and vital evidence of early structural activity (temporary thatched shelters or windbreaks) built by early humans.

Q 8. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Chirand, located in the Saran district of Bihar, is a highly significant archaeological site celebrated for its Neolithic deposits.
- The most important feature of the Neolithic culture at Chirand is the discovery of a massive, rich collection of tools and weapons made entirely of bone, particularly from the antlers of deer. This makes it exceptionally rare, as the only other major Neolithic site in India known for such extensive bone tool industry is Burzahom in Kashmir.

Site	Primary Significance	Region
Chirand	Massive Bone Tool industry (Antlers)	Bihar (Ganges Valley)

Burzahom	Pit-dwellings & Bone tools	Kashmir
Mehrgarh	Earliest agriculture (Wheat/Barley)	Balochistan
Koldihwa	Earliest evidence of Rice cultivation	Uttar Pradesh (Belan Valley)
Piklihal	Ashmounds (Cattle herding)	Karnataka (South India)

Q 9. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** The northern province of Uttarapatha was governed from Taxila, which served as the major administrative and commercial hub of the northwest. Taxila’s strategic location at the junction of important trade routes connecting Central Asia, Persia, and the Gangetic plains made it the natural capital for administering the northwestern frontier of the Mauryan Empire.
- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** The southern province of Dakshinapatha was administered from Suvarnagiri, meaning “golden mountain,” which is identified with the gold-bearing regions of the southern Deccan. Ashokan Minor Rock Edicts found in the Chitradurga area of Karnataka confirm the administrative importance of Suvarnagiri as the command centre for Mauryan authority in the south.
- **Pair 3 is incorrectly matched:** Avantiratha, the western province centred on the Avanti region, was administered from Ujjain, not Tosali. Ujjain was one of the most important cities of ancient India and served as the provincial capital of the western Mauryan territories. Ashoka himself is traditionally associated with Ujjain, having served there as a prince and governor before ascending the throne.
- **Pair 4 is incorrectly matched:** Kalinga was administered from Tosali, not Ujjain. Following Ashoka’s conquest of Kalinga, Tosali was established as its administrative headquarters. The Separate Rock Edicts specifically addressed to the Kalinga region are found at Dhauli, which is identified with ancient Tosali itself.

Q 10. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Archaeological evidence suggests that the Harappans obtained a major portion of their copper from the Khetri copper mines of Rajasthan.
- Gold used by the Harappans is believed to have been obtained mainly from Afghanistan and South India, especially the Karnataka region.
- Tin was a rare metal in the Harappan civilisation and was likely imported mainly from Afghanistan.
- Ancient tin workings have been reported from Hazaribagh in present-day Jharkhand.
- Afghanistan's Badakhshan region was the primary and best source for lapis lazuli, a highly valued precious/semi-precious stone.

Q 11. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The Rig Veda describes the Dasyus as worshippers of non-Aryan deities.
 - ✓ Aryans worshipped Devas, whereas Dasyus were often associated with hostile or demon-like forces such as Vritra.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Rigveda describes Dasyus as having fortified settlements (pur), possessing wealth including cattle and gold, and being formidable enough to require Indra's intervention to defeat.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Trasadasyu was not a Dasyu chief; he was an Aryan chief mentioned in the Rig Veda.
 - ✓ He is known for defeating the Dasyus, and his name literally means "destroyer of the Dasyus."

Q 12. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Jagaddala Mahavihara was founded by the Pala ruler Ramapala (c. 1077-1130 CE), one of the later and more significant Pala kings, in the Varendra region of northern Bengal, corresponding broadly to the modern Rajshahi area.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** As Nalanda and Vikramshila declined under the pressures of

the late Pala period and subsequent Ghurid incursions, Jagaddala emerged as a refuge for displaced Vajrayana scholars. It developed a specialised tradition of translating Sanskrit Tantric and Buddhist philosophical texts into Tibetan. When Jagaddala itself was destroyed around 1203 CE, fleeing scholars carried manuscripts directly to Tibet, making the institution critically important to the preservation and transmission of late Indian Buddhist learning into the Tibetan tradition.

- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The library complex named Dharmaganja belonged to Nalanda University, not Jagaddala. Xuanzang's account specifically identifies Dharmaganja as Nalanda's library, described as comprising multiple multi-storeyed buildings.
 - ✓ The architecture of the Pala-era Mahaviharas in the eastern region was characteristically made of baked terracotta bricks in a structural layout, not rock-cut underground vaults, which are characteristic of Western Indian or Deccan architecture (like Ajanta or Ellora).

Q 13. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Junagadh inscription of Skandagupta traces the administrative history of Sudarshana Lake from its original construction during Chandragupta Maurya's governorship under Pushyagupta, through the addition of irrigation channels during Ashoka's time under his governor Tushaspa, through Rudradaman's repair of an earlier breach recorded on the same Girnar rock, and finally to Skandagupta's own repair. The inscription thus establishes an unbroken thread of state responsibility for the lake across Mauryan, Shaka Kshatrapa, and Gupta regimes on a single epigraphic surface.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Vishti in Gupta-period administrative vocabulary referred to corvée labour or obligatory labour service extracted from subjects, not a special emergency tax. More critically, the inscription explicitly emphasises that Chakrapalita accomplished the repair without imposing any financial or labour burden on the local population, using personal resources and administrative initiative.

- **Statement 3 is correct:** The inscription records Skandagupta's appointment of Parnadatta as the governor of Saurashtra. This appointment was strategically motivated by the need to stabilise and secure the western frontier of the Gupta Empire at a time when Huna pressure from the northwest was intensifying, making Saurashtra a critical western bulwark.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** Chakrapalita, son of the provincial governor Parnadatta, personally supervised and completed the repair of the breached embankment of Sudarshana Lake. The inscription records that the masonry embankment was restored within two months, which shows both the urgency and administrative efficiency of the operation.

Q 14. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Pragjyotisha was the ancient name for the kingdom corresponding to present-day Assam in northeastern India.
- The name literally means the place of eastern light or the land of the first light of dawn, reflecting its geographical position as the easternmost significant kingdom known to the authors of early Indian texts.
- Pragjyotisha finds mention in the Mahabharata, the Puranas, and several early medieval inscriptions and is closely associated with the legendary king Bhagadatta, who participated in the Kurukshetra war.
- In historical terms, the region later became known as Kamarupa, the name used in the early medieval period under the Varman dynasty, whose rulers styled themselves as kings of Kamarupa.
- The Allahabad Pillar inscription of Samudragupta mentions Kamarupa as a frontier kingdom that maintained cordial relations with the Gupta Empire, and Bhaskaravarman of the Varman dynasty is historically recorded as the ally of Emperor Harsha.
- The region's geographical isolation beyond the Brahmaputra river system allowed it to maintain political independence through most of ancient and early medieval Indian history.

Q 15. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The First Jain Council was held at Pataliputra around the 3rd century BCE, during the reign of Chandragupta Maurya, under the presidency of Sthulabhadra.
- The council was convened in response to a serious crisis within the Jain monastic community caused by a prolonged famine that had driven a large section of the Jain monks, led by Bhadrabahu, to migrate southward to Karnataka.
- The monks who remained at Pataliputra under Sthulabhadra compiled the Jain canonical texts during this period, producing the twelve Angas that form the scriptural foundation of the Shvetambara sect.
- When Bhadrabahu and his followers returned from the south, they refused to accept this compilation on the grounds that it had been produced in their absence and that they had preserved the original oral teachings more faithfully.
- This disagreement over canonical authenticity and over the issue of whether monks should wear white robes or remain unclothed ultimately formalised the split between the Shvetambara and Digambara sects of Jainism.
- Mahavira was the 24th Tirthankara who had attained Nirvana around 527 BCE and was therefore not present at the council.
- Sudharman was one of the direct disciples of Mahavira from an earlier period.
- Bhadrabahu was the senior Jain elder who led the southern migration and did not preside over the Pataliputra council.

Q 16. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Harsha convened the Kannauj assembly around 643 CE specifically to promote Mahayana Buddhist doctrines and to provide a formal platform for Xuanzang to present and defend Mahayana philosophy before an audience of scholars, kings, and religious figures drawn from across the subcontinent. Harsha, who had shifted his personal religious orientation toward Mahayana Buddhism, used the assembly to publicly honour Xuanzang and legitimise Mahayana doctrinal positions.

The assembly was attended by approximately 20 vassal kings, thousands of Buddhist monks, and representatives of Brahmanical and Jain traditions, and it lasted for 23 days according to Xuanzang's own account.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Prayag Mahamoksha Parishad was not an annual event but a quinquennial one, held every five years at the Triveni Sangam at Prayag. Additionally, the donations were not restricted to Brahmanas. Harsha distributed the entire accumulated treasury of five years among Buddhist monks, Brahmanas, the poor, the destitute, and heretics, effectively giving away everything, including his personal ornaments and clothing. Xuanzang records that Harsha borrowed a plain garment from his sister at the conclusion of the ceremony. The assembly was a broad charitable event rooted in the Buddhist dana tradition.

Q 17. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Kushana Empire occupied a uniquely advantageous geographical position, controlling the overland Silk Route that connected the Roman Empire in the west with China and Southeast Asia in the east. The Kushanas extracted substantial transit tolls and taxes from merchants and trading caravans passing through their territory, which stretched across modern Afghanistan, Pakistan, and northern India. This steady accumulation of wealth, including large inflows of Roman gold coins, provided the Kushanas with the bullion base necessary to mint their famous gold dinaras in large quantities and at high purity levels. The Kushana gold dinara was, in fact modelled closely on the Roman aureus in weight and purity, directly reflecting the Roman gold that flowed into Kushana coffers through Silk Route commerce.
- The Kolar gold mines in Karnataka were not under Kushana control and were geographically far outside their territory.

Q 18. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Mesopotamian records dating from around 2350 BCE mention trade relations with a region

called Meluha. Historians generally identify Meluha with the Indus Valley (Harappan) region because many Harappan seals have been found in Mesopotamia, and evidence suggests active trade between the two civilisations. The Harappans exported finished goods and imported raw materials through maritime and overland trade routes. Mesopotamian texts also mention intermediary trading centres such as Dilmun (identified with present-day Bahrain) and Makan, located between Mesopotamia and Meluha.

Q 19. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **First Board: Supervision of industries and artisans:**
 - ✓ The first committee was responsible for overseeing industrial crafts and artisan production within Pataliputra.
- **Second Board: Care and supervision of foreigners:**
 - ✓ A dedicated committee managed the welfare, accommodation, and movement of foreigners in Pataliputra, including foreign envoys and travelling merchants, reflecting the cosmopolitan character of the Mauryan capital.
- **Third Board: Registration of births and deaths:**
 - ✓ A separate committee maintained official demographic records by registering births and deaths within the city, representing an early instance of state-level population documentation in ancient India.
- **Fourth Board: Regulation of trade, commerce, weights and measures:**
 - ✓ The fourth committee supervised market transactions, standardised weights and measures, and regulated commercial activity to prevent fraud in the city's markets.

Q 20. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Spindle whorls discovered at Harappan sites were used for spinning thread, showing that the Harappans practised textile production and weaving.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The presence of massive brick structures indicates that brick-laying was an advanced craft and that a specialised class of masons existed in Harappan society.

- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Harappans were familiar with boat-making and practised navigation along the Arabian Sea for trade and transport.

Q 21. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The defining characteristic of the Shvetambara sect is that its monks and nuns are permitted to wear white robes. The name Shvetambara itself literally means white-clad, directly reflecting this practice. This stood in deliberate contrast to the Digambara position that complete nudity was an essential requirement of the highest monastic renunciation.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Digambara tradition held that women could not attain moksha or spiritual liberation in their female form. According to the Digambara doctrine, liberation required complete nudity as an absolute precondition, and since women were not permitted to practice nudity, they were considered incapable of achieving final liberation in their current birth. They would need to be reborn as men to progress toward moksha. The Shvetambara tradition took the opposite position, holding that women were fully capable of attaining liberation, and cited the example of Mallinatha, the 19th Tirthankara, whom the Shvetambaras identify as female, a claim the Digambaras reject.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The formal split between the Digambara and Shvetambara sects did not occur during Mahavira's lifetime. The division crystallised gradually and became institutionally definitive only around the time of the First Jain Council at Pataliputra in the 3rd century BCE, approximately two centuries after Mahavira's Nirvana, when the disputes over canonical texts, monastic practice, and the question of nudity hardened into two distinct and irreconcilable sectarian positions.

Q 22. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Bhaga was the primary land revenue tax representing the king's

customary share of agricultural produce. The Arthashastra records this share as typically one-sixth of the total produce, which is why the king is frequently referred to in ancient texts as Shadbhagaharika, meaning the receiver of one-sixth. Bhaga formed the single most important source of revenue for the Mauryan state and was collected directly from cultivators across the empire.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Bali was not a voluntary religious offering in the Mauryan fiscal system. While the term Bali originally carried a ritualistic connotation of offering in Vedic literature, by the Mauryan period, it had evolved into a compulsory additional levy extracted by the state over and above the primary Bhaga assessment. The Arthashastra treats Bali as a mandatory fiscal impost, making it an obligatory state extraction with no voluntary character whatsoever.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Hiranya was a specialised tax collected in cash rather than in kind and was applied specifically to gardens, vegetable plots, and flower cultivation, which were commercial agricultural activities that generated monetary income. The cash-based nature of Hiranya reflects the monetised character of certain sectors of the Mauryan agricultural economy, particularly horticultural and market-oriented cultivation that operated outside the standard grain-based revenue framework.

Q 23. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Ptolemy Philadelphus was the ruler of the Ptolemaic Kingdom of Egypt, the Hellenistic dynasty founded by Ptolemy I, one of Alexander the Great's generals, following the fragmentation of Alexander's empire after his death in 323 BCE.
- Ptolemy Philadelphus, who ruled from 285 to 246 BCE, dispatched the ambassador Dionysius to the Mauryan court, as part of the active diplomatic exchange that was maintained between the Mauryan Empire and the Hellenistic kingdoms of the post-Alexandrine world.
- This diplomatic contact is attested in classical sources and reflects the broader pattern of Mauryan engagement with the Hellenistic

world, which also included Chandragupta Maurya's treaty with Seleucus Nicator and Bindusara's correspondence with Antiochus I of Syria.

- The dispatch of Dionysius from Egypt demonstrates that Mauryan diplomatic reach extended not only to the Seleucid kingdom in Syria and Persia but also to the Ptolemaic kingdom in North Africa, highlighting the international diplomatic standing of the Mauryan Empire within the wider ancient world.

Q 24. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Sutkagendor is a Harappan site located in the Baluchistan province of Pakistan near the Iran border and represents the westernmost known site of the Indus Valley Civilisation.
- Kot Diji is an important site in Sindh, Pakistan, known for its Early Harappan (pre-Harappan) culture that continued into the Mature Harappan phase.
- Amri is an important Harappan site located in the Dadu district of Sindh province in Pakistan.
- Manda is a Harappan site situated on the right bank of the Chenab River in the foothills of the Pir Panjal range, about 28 km northwest of Jammu.

Q 25. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** James Prinsep, a British antiquary and officer of the East India Company, successfully deciphered the Brahmi script in 1837. This breakthrough unlocked the entire corpus of Ashokan inscriptions and opened the field of ancient Indian epigraphy. Prinsep's decipherment is considered one of the most consequential contributions to the study of ancient Indian history.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Brahmi was written from left to right, not from right to left. The right-to-left direction is a characteristic of the Kharosthi script, which was used in the northwestern regions of the Mauryan Empire and was itself derived from the Aramaic script.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Ashoka's edicts were not composed in Sanskrit. They were written in

Prakrit, specifically in regional Prakrit dialects that varied according to the geographical location of the edict. The edicts found in the northwest at Kandahar are partially in Greek and Aramaic, reflecting the linguistic realities of those frontier populations. Sanskrit became the dominant language of royal inscriptions only during the Gupta period. Ashoka's deliberate use of Prakrit was a conscious political and communicative choice to reach ordinary people in their spoken everyday languages.

Q 26. Ans. D

Explanation:

- The famous Pashupati seal depicts a horned male figure seated in a cross-legged yogic posture.
 - ✓ The figure is often associated with a proto-Shiva form.
- Phallus (linga-like) symbols discovered at Harappan sites are linked with fertility worship and religious practices.
- Dilmun, identified with the present-day Bahrain region, acted as an important trade centre between Mesopotamia and the Harappan civilisation.
- Mesopotamian texts refer to the Harappan region as Meluha.
 - ✓ These records provide evidence of trade relations between the two civilisations.

Q 27. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** Amarasimha authored the Amarakosha, a Sanskrit lexicon organised into three kandas grouping words by semantic categories such as celestial beings, earthly phenomena, human activities, and grammatical forms. This thematic rather than alphabetical organisation made it an indispensable reference tool for Sanskrit scholars, poets, and students throughout the medieval period, and it remains in active use today.
- **Pair 2 is incorrectly matched:** Dhanvantari was a physician and Ayurvedic scholar, not a specialist in structural temple architecture. He is associated with medical knowledge, specifically with the Ayurvedic tradition, and is venerated in

later tradition as a deity of medicine. Engineering principles of temple architecture fall under the domain of Vastu Shastra literature.

- **Pair 3 is correctly matched:** Vararuchi is credited with the Prakrit Prakasha, considered the foundational authoritative grammar of the Prakrit language. He systematised the phonological and morphological rules governing Prakrit, making his contribution to Prakrit linguistics directly comparable to Panini's role in the Sanskrit grammatical tradition.
- **Pair 4 is incorrectly matched:** Astronomy and mathematical planetary calculations within the Navaratna tradition are associated with Varahamihira, whose Brihatsamhita, Panchasiddhantika, and Brihat Jataka established him as the foremost astronomical and astrological authority of the Gupta period. Shanku was historically associated with architecture (Shilpashastra).

Q 28. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The earliest specimen of the Harappan script was first noticed in 1853 when Alexander Cunningham, the first Director-General of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), discovered the first inscribed Harappan seal. While extensive excavations to uncover the broader civilisation and fully recognise its significance began much later in the 1920s (led by figures like John Marshall and Daya Ram Sahni), the initial sighting of the script on a steatite seal dates back to 1853.

Q 29. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Harappan civilisation utilised a standardised weighing system predominantly based on 16 and its multiples (16, 64, 160), a tradition that survived in India until recently (e.g., 16 annas = 1 Rupee).
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Measuring instruments were not made exclusively of bronze; archaeologists have also found measuring scales made of ivory at Lothal and shell at Mohenjo-Daro.

Q 30. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Buddhist Pali texts, including the Vinaya Pitaka and various Jataka stories set in the Magadhan social context, frequently use the term Gahapati to refer to wealthy householders and prosperous landowners who occupied a position of considerable social and economic importance below the ruling Kshatriya class. The Gahapati represented an emerging propertied class whose wealth was based on land ownership, trade, and craft production, and their growing social significance is closely linked to the economic transformations of the Mahajanapada period in Magadha.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Haryanka dynasty, associated with rulers such as Bimbisara and Ajatashatru, was focused primarily on military expansion, political consolidation, and administrative organisation. The Varna system continued to function as the dominant social framework throughout this period.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The top administrative officials of the Haryanka period were drawn from Brahmanical and Kshatriya backgrounds, consistent with the established social hierarchy of the period. While merchant guilds did acquire considerable economic influence during this period, their social and political role remained distinct from formal state administration, which continued to reflect the existing varna-based social order.

Q 31. Ans. C

Explanation:

- According to Jain tradition, Chandragupta Maurya abdicated the throne in favour of his son Bindusara, renounced worldly life, and accompanied the Jain monk Bhadrabahu southward to Shravanabelagola in present-day Karnataka.
- There, he undertook Sallekhana, the Jain practice of voluntarily fasting unto death as the ultimate act of spiritual renunciation, and died at the site known as Chandragiri hill, which bears his name to this day.
- This tradition is preserved in Jain texts and is commemorated at Shravanabelagola, which became one of the most sacred pilgrimage sites of the Digambara Jain tradition.

- Ashoka is associated with Buddhism, not Jainism.
- Bindusara is associated with the Ajivika sect.
- Dasharatha, Ashoka's grandson, donated the Nagarjuni caves to the Ajivikas.

Q 32. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Panini's Ashtadhyayi, composed around the 4th century BCE in the northwestern region of Gandhara, is one of the greatest intellectual achievements of the ancient world and remains the foundational text of Sanskrit grammatical science.
- The title itself means the text of eight chapters, and within these eight chapters, Panini formulated approximately 3,966 highly compressed sutras, or grammatical rules, that together constitute a complete and self-sufficient generative grammar of the Sanskrit language.
- The rules govern phonology, morphology, word formation, syntax, and the derivation of all possible correct Sanskrit forms from a set of root elements.
- The system is so precisely constructed that modern linguists and computer scientists have compared its logical architecture to formal computational grammars, and it is considered the earliest example of a descriptive linguistic system of such rigour anywhere in the world. Panini's Ashtadhyayi also serves as an important historical source because its incidental references to political geography, social customs, trade, and the names of contemporary rulers and regions provide valuable evidence for reconstructing the cultural and political world of northwestern India in the pre-Mauryan period.
- The text later received two major commentaries, the Mahabhashya of Patanjali and the Kashika Vritti of Jayaditya and Vamana, which together form the classical trimurti of Sanskrit grammatical literature.

Q 33. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Harappan cities like Mohenjo-Daro and Harappa had incredibly sophisticated sanitation and planned drainage systems. Almost every house had its own bathroom and was connected

to the main street drains. These street drains were covered with baked bricks or stone slabs, equipped with manholes at regular intervals for cleaning, and featured soak pits. While Mesopotamian cities had some rudimentary drainage, it was rarely as systematic, widespread, or meticulously planned as the Harappan system.

Q 34. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Eran pillar inscription, dated to 510 CE, associated with the Gupta ruler Bhanugupta, records that a warrior named Goparaja died fighting in battle and that his devoted wife followed him into death on the funeral pyre. This inscription is universally recognised as the earliest dated epigraphic evidence of the practice of Sati in ancient India. The fact that the act is recorded with a tone of honour and admiration indicates that by the early 6th century CE, the practice was beginning to acquire social prestige among the warrior class.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Katyayana's position on women's property rights was notably more progressive than earlier Dharmashastra authorities. Katyayana explicitly expanded the definition of Stridhan and recognised a widow's right to inherit her deceased husband's property in the absence of male heirs, directly contradicting the restrictive positions taken by earlier Smriti writers such as Manu. His recognition of widow inheritance rights marked a significant departure within the Dharmashastra tradition and is frequently cited as evidence of evolving legal attitudes toward women's property entitlements in the post-Gupta period.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Vatsyayana's Kamasutra states that educated upper-class urban women, especially those belonging to the nagarika (urban elite) society, were expected to be trained in 64 arts, known as Chatushashti Kalas. These arts included music, dance, painting, poetry, flower arrangement, and many other fine arts and practical skills. This shows that formal training in artistic and aesthetic skills was considered an important social accomplishment for women of the educated urban elite in ancient India.

Q 35. Ans. C**Explanation:**

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Nalanda's foundation is attributed to the Gupta emperor Kumaragupta I, identified in Xuanzang's account by the epithet Shakraditya. It followed a systematic north-south layout where the residential monasteries (viharas) ran along the eastern side and the temples (chaityas) along the western side, effectively aligned along a central longitudinal axis.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Admission at Nalanda was neither decentralised nor open. Xuanzang's travelogue records that entry was contingent on passing a rigorous oral examination at the gate itself. The process was highly selective and centrally controlled, with the vast majority of aspirants being turned away. No open enrollment existed for local populations, irrespective of prior learning.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Xuanzang's account describes a learned gatekeeper positioned at the entrance of Nalanda whose role was to engage incoming aspirants in sophisticated philosophical debate. This figure, referred to in scholarly literature as the Dvara-Pandita (gate scholar), functioned as the primary intellectual filter. Only those who demonstrated sufficient debating skills and philosophical grounding were permitted to enter and study.

Q 36. Ans. D**Explanation:**

- Painted Grey Ware (PGW) is most accurately associated with the Vedic people (specifically, the Later Vedic phase).
- PGW is an Iron Age culture (c. 1200 BCE – 600 BCE) centred in the western Gangetic plain and the Ghaggar-Hakra valley. This geographical and chronological footprint aligns perfectly with the settlement patterns of the Later Aryans/Vedic people as they moved eastward into the Ganga-Yamuna Doab. The pottery is characterised by a fine, high-quality grey fabric painted with black geometric patterns (lines, dots, concentric circles).

Q 37. Ans. B**Explanation:**

- Knossos: It is known for its well-planned urban features, including an advanced drainage and water management system.
- Painted Grey Ware is linked with the Later Vedic phase. It is mainly found in the Gangetic region and is associated with Mahabharata-era settlements.
- Mohenjo-daro showed evidence of decline in its later phase. Archaeologists found signs such as hastily built houses, encroachments on streets, and buried valuables, indicating insecurity and urban decay.
- The Harappan script was an indigenous pictographic script. It appeared mainly on seals, pottery, and tablets, though it remains undeciphered.

Q 38. Ans. A**Explanation:**

- Apala was a Brahmavadini who composed hymn 91 of the eighth Mandala of the Rigveda, making her one of the approximately 27 women seers whose compositions are preserved in the Rigvedic corpus.
- Her hymn is addressed to Indra and is notable for its deeply personal character.
- According to Vedic tradition, Apala suffered from a skin disease and was consequently rejected and abandoned by her husband.
- She is said to have discovered the Soma plant while drawing water and offered it to Indra with sincere devotion. Indra, pleased by her offering and devotion, passed her through the hole of his chariot wheel three times and miraculously cured her skin condition, restoring her hair and complexion.
- Her hymn reflects this personal narrative of suffering, devotion, divine grace, and physical restoration.

Q 39. Ans. B**Explanation:**

- In the 6th century BCE, the western parts of the subcontinent (present Pakistan and Afghanistan) had many small but rich kingdoms

such as Kamboja, Kekaya, Gandhara, and Madra. Unlike Magadha in the east, no strong ruler united these states, making the region vulnerable to Persian expansion.

- Cyrus the Great (559–530 BCE), founder of the Persian Empire, attacked this region. He faced strong resistance from tribes living between Sindh and Kabul. Greek writer Arrian mentions the Ashtaka and Ashvaka tribes as leading this resistance. Their attack was so strong that Cyrus had to retreat and escaped with only seven companions.
- Patanjali, in the Mahabhashya, called these tribes Ashtake Namadhanvah, meaning “tribe with a powerful name”, to honour their successful resistance against Cyrus

Q 40. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Hathigumpha inscription, carved into the Elephant Cave at Udayagiri hill near Bhubaneswar in Odisha, is the primary epigraphic record of the Chedi king Kharavela's reign. It records his military campaigns, public works, and religious patronage across seventeen lines of Brahmi script and is the most important source for reconstructing early post-Mauryan political history in Kalinga.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Hathigumpha inscription explicitly records that Kharavela recovered a sacred Jain image of the first Tirthankara Rishabhanatha that had been taken away from Kalinga by a Nanda ruler. The recovery and reinstallation of this idol was presented as a major act of Jain piety and royal legitimacy by Kharavela.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The monumental Gommateshwara statue of Bahubali at Shravanabelagola was commissioned by Chamundaraya, a minister and general of the Ganga dynasty, around 981 CE. Chandragupta Maurya is associated with Shravanabelagola through the Jain tradition of his Sallekhana death at Chandragiri hill, but he had no connection to the Gommateshwara statue, which was erected over a thousand years after his death.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** The Kadamba dynasty of Karnataka, which ruled from the 4th to

6th century CE, extended patronage to Jain institutions alongside Brahmanical traditions. The Karnataka region, in general, had a strong Jain presence throughout the early medieval period under successive dynasties, including the Gangas, Kadambas, and Chalukyas.

Q 41. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** Although the Harappan civilisation belongs to the Bronze Age, they did not use bronze extensively in its daily lives. Tin, which is needed to alloy with copper to make bronze, was scarce and had to be imported (likely from Afghanistan or Central Asia). Therefore, bronze was a luxury metal used mostly for specialised crafts, weapons, or statues (like the famous Dancing Girl).
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Harappan script (often referred to as the Indus script) is an indigenous, predominantly pictographic or logo-syllabic script. It has not been deciphered yet. It bears no close resemblance or proven linguistic connection to Egyptian hieroglyphs or Mesopotamian cuneiform.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The Indus Valley Civilisation covered a vast geographical area, significantly larger than its contemporaries in Egypt and Mesopotamia combined. It encompassed parts of modern-day Pakistan, Afghanistan, and northwestern India.
 - ✓ Northernmost site: Manda (Jammu and Kashmir)
 - ✓ Southernmost site: Daimabad (Maharashtra)
 - ✓ Easternmost site: Alamgirpur (Uttar Pradesh)
 - ✓ Westernmost site: Sutkagen Dor (Makran coast, Pakistan)

Q 42. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Pratityasamutpada, meaning dependent origination or conditioned co-arising, is one of the most fundamental doctrines of Buddhist philosophy and forms the theoretical backbone of the Buddha's understanding of existence, suffering, and liberation.

- The doctrine holds that nothing in existence arises independently or possesses inherent self-existence, but that every phenomenon arises in dependence upon specific causes and conditions, and ceases when those causes and conditions are removed.
- The Buddha articulated this principle in the formula “when this is, that is; when this ceases, that ceases,” expressing the universal law of conditioned causation that governs all physical and mental phenomena.
- Pratityasamutpada is classically elaborated through the Twelve Nidanas, a chain of twelve causally linked factors beginning with Avidya (ignorance) and ending with Jara-Marana (old age and death), which together explain how suffering and rebirth perpetuate themselves through causal interdependence. Breaking any link in this chain, particularly the root link of ignorance, leads to the cessation of suffering and the attainment of Nirvana.
- Nagarjuna later made Pratityasamutpada the philosophical foundation of his Madhyamaka school, equating dependent origination with Shunyata or emptiness. A
- nekantavada and Syadvada are Jain doctrines relating to the many-sidedness of reality and conditional predication, respectively, entirely distinct from Buddhist philosophy.
- Brahmacharya refers to the practice of celibacy and is a disciplinary observance common to multiple Indian religious traditions.

Q 43. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Rig Veda consists of 10 books or Mandalas. Books II to VII are the oldest parts of the text. They are often referred to as the “Family Books” because each of these mandalas is attributed to a specific family of seers or sages (Rishis), such as Gritsamada, Vishvamitra, Vamadeva, Atri, Bharadvaja, and Vashistha.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Books I and X are the youngest and longest books of the Rig Veda. They were added at a later stage. This is evident from differences in their linguistic style, vocabulary, and the societal structures they describe. For instance, the famous Purusha Sukta, which contains the earliest reference to the fourfold Varna system, is found in Mandala X.

- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Rig Veda was not composed in Prakrit. It was composed orally in an ancient, highly formalised form of Sanskrit known as Vedic Sanskrit. Prakrit, on the other hand, refers to a group of vernacular, colloquial languages that developed much later and were commonly spoken by the masses (and heavily utilised later in Buddhist and Jain texts).

Q 44. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Mathura School used locally quarried spotted red sandstone from the Sikri region near Fatehpur Sikri. This distinctive material gives Mathura sculptures their characteristic warm reddish appearance with white spots, and is one of the clearest markers distinguishing Mathura art from the grey schist used in Gandhara sculpture.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Mathura School developed as a predominantly indigenous artistic tradition rooted in earlier Yaksha and Yakshi sculptural forms of the Shunga and early Kushana period. Unlike the Gandhara School, which absorbed heavy Hellenistic and Roman artistic influences in facial features, drapery, and compositional style, the Mathura tradition evolved organically from within the Indian artistic vocabulary, even while both schools flourished simultaneously under Kushana patronage.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The iconographic range of the Mathura School was far broader than Mahayana Buddhism alone. Mathura artists produced sculptures for multiple religious traditions simultaneously, including Hinayana Buddhist figures, Jain Tirthankaras, Brahmanical deities such as Shiva, Vishnu, and Surya, as well as Yaksha and Naga figures rooted in popular folk worship. This religious plurality makes Mathura one of the most iconographically diverse artistic centres of ancient India and reflects the composite religious character of the city itself during the Kushana period.

Q 45. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Dashavatara temple at Deogarh, Uttar Pradesh, dated to around the

5th-6th century CE, is one of the earliest surviving Panchayatana-plan stone temples of the Gupta period. It features a curvilinear shikhara over the sanctum, though the shikhara survives only partially today. The temple is architecturally significant as an early transitional example of the emerging Nagara style, and its three surviving exterior niches containing the Vishnu Anantashayana, Nara-Narayana, and Gajendra-Moksha panels represent the finest examples of Gupta sculptural art in a structural temple setting.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Dashavatara temple at Deogarh follows the Nagara architectural tradition of north India, characterised by a curvilinear shikhara over the garbhagriha. The Dravidian style, which features a pyramidal tiered vimana, was confined to peninsular India and not found in the Deogarh temple or any other Gupta-period monument in the Gangetic and central Indian region.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The brick temple at Bhitargaon in Kanpur district, Uttar Pradesh, is among the finest surviving Gupta-period brick temples and is architecturally significant for its early use of a true radiating arch constructed with wedge-shaped bricks. This distinguishes it from corbelled arch construction, where bricks are progressively projected inward without a true radiating arrangement.

Q 46. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Shreni was the primary form of organised economic association in ancient India, functioning as a guild that brought together artisans, craftsmen, or merchants belonging to the same trade or craft.
- During the Mauryan period, Shrenis were well-established institutions that regulated production standards, fixed wages, settled internal disputes, provided training to new members, and collectively negotiated with the state over taxation and trade terms.
- The Arthashastra of Kautilya contains specific references to Shrenis and prescribes how the state should interact with, regulate, and utilise them, including deploying Shrenis of craftsmen for state manufacturing needs.
- Shrenis also functioned as banking institutions, accepting deposits from the public and paying

interest, a role attested in both the Arthashastra and later Buddhist Jataka literature. They were headed by an elected or hereditary chief called the Shreshthim or Jetthaka in Pali sources.

- Sabha and Samiti were Vedic political assemblies with no connection to trade or craft organisations.
- Ur was a term used in Sangam-period Tamil inscriptions to denote a village assembly in the southern agrarian context.

Q 47. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The Rig Veda is a literary and religious text, not an archaeological source. While it provides immense textual information about the geographical location (the Sapta Sindhu region), society, and culture of the Early Vedic people, it does not provide archaeological evidence. In fact, identifying clear and uncontested archaeological evidence (like physical ruins or distinct pottery) for the Early Aryans remains one of the major challenges in ancient Indian history.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Early Vedic (Rigvedic) economy was predominantly pastoral. Cattle rearing was their main occupation, and a person's wealth was measured by the number of cows they owned (Gomat). Many wars were fought over cattle, known as Gavisti (literally "search for cows"). Agriculture was known to them (they grew Yava or barley), but it occupied a secondary position compared to pastoralism during this early phase.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The scarcity of substantial archaeological remains for the Early Aryans is largely due to their semi-nomadic, pastoral lifestyle. Unlike the Harappans who built well-planned cities with baked bricks, the Early Vedic people were constantly on the move with their herds. They likely lived in temporary structures made of wood, bamboo, and thatch, which do not survive well in the archaeological record over millennia.

Q 48. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Xuanzang's travelogue records that Shilabhadra was the presiding

head of Nalanda at the time of his visit in the 7th century CE, a role conventionally described in modern scholarship as that of Chancellor. Shilabhadra was a direct disciple of Dharmapala and the foremost authority on Yogachara (Vijnanavada) philosophy at Nalanda. Xuanzang studied the Yogacarabhumi-shastra specifically under his guidance, making Shilabhadra central to the transmission of Yogachara thought to East Asia.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** Dharmapala, predecessor of Shilabhadra, was a major Yogachara philosopher and successor to Dignaga's tradition of Buddhist logic and epistemology (pramana-shastra). He wrote commentaries on Vasubandhu's Vijnaptimatratna texts and works of the Dignaga school, strengthening Nalanda's engagement with Mahayana philosophy and logical inquiry, shaping the curriculum inherited by later scholars.

Q 49. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Vasishtha:** Vasishtha was the priest of the Bharatas. The famous Battle of Ten Kings (Dasarajna) was sparked when Sudas, the king of the Bharata tribe, removed Vishvamitra from the position of chief priest and appointed Vasishtha in his place.
- **Kurus:** Despite winning the Battle of Ten Kings, the Bharatas eventually formed an alliance with the Purus, who were one of the major tribes they had just defeated. This new, amalgamated tribe formed after the Bharata-Puru alliance came to be known as the Kurus.
- **Battle of Ten Kings:** Also known as the Dasarajna war, this was a major conflict fought on the banks of the Parushni River (the modern-day Ravi River). King Sudas of the Bharata tribe emerged victorious against a confederacy of ten tribes (five Aryan and five non-Aryan) led by Vishvamitra.
- **Panchalas:** The newly formed Kuru tribe later expanded its influence and allied with the Panchalas. Together, the Kuru-Panchalas went on to establish a dominant kingdom in the upper Gangetic basin during the Later Vedic period.

Q 50. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Northern Black Polished Ware, commonly abbreviated as NBPW, is a fine luxury pottery tradition characterised by its distinctive metallic sheen and highly polished black or steel-grey surface finish. It first appears in the archaeological record around 700-600 BCE and reaches its widest geographical distribution and greatest abundance during the Mauryan period from the 4th to 2nd century BCE, which is why it is most closely associated with that era.
- NBPW has been found across an extraordinarily wide geographical range stretching from Taxila in the northwest to Bengal in the east and from the Himalayan foothills in the north to the Deccan in the south, reflecting the extensive trade networks, urban growth, and political integration that characterised the Mauryan imperial system.
- The wide distribution of NBPW across major excavated sites such as Pataliputra, Taxila, Kaushambi, Vaishali, Rajgriha, and Mathura makes it the single most important ceramic marker for identifying Mauryan period archaeological layers.
- Its association with urban sites, elite contexts, and high-quality craft production also makes it an important indicator of the level of economic sophistication and long-distance commercial exchange that underpinned the Mauryan economy.

Q 51. Ans. B

Explanation:

- In the Rigveda, the term "gavisthi" literally means "search for cows" or "struggle for cows."
- The word is derived from:
 - "Go" = cow
 - "Visthi" = search or pursuit
- **Significance:**
 - ✓ Cattle were the main measure of wealth in Rig Vedic society.
 - ✓ Many tribal conflicts and wars were fought for the possession of cows.
 - ✓ Therefore, the term "gavisthi" was often used synonymously with war or conflict.

Q 52. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** Ananda was the Buddha's closest personal attendant and had committed all of the Buddha's discourses to memory through direct proximity over decades. At the First Buddhist Council held at Rajgriha shortly after the Buddha's Mahaparinirvana, Ananda recited the Sutta Pitaka from memory before the assembled Sangha.
- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** Upali, originally a barber by birth, became one of the most disciplined members of the Sangha and was regarded as the foremost authority on monastic rules among all the Buddha's disciples. At the First Buddhist Council, Upali was assigned the task of reciting the Vinaya Pitaka, the code of monastic discipline.
- **Pair 3 is correctly matched:** Sujata was a young woman from Bodh Gaya who offered a bowl of milk-rice to the Buddha at the moment when he had abandoned the path of extreme asceticism and was regaining his physical strength before his final meditation and enlightenment under the Bodhi tree. This offering is considered a pivotal moment in the Buddha's journey toward enlightenment in Buddhist tradition.
- **Pair 4 is incorrectly matched:** Devadatta was a cousin of the Buddha who became a monk but later grew ambitious and attempted to take over the leadership of the Sangha. He is remembered in Buddhist texts for making three separate attempts to assassinate the Buddha, including releasing a rogue elephant and rolling a boulder toward him. He was the most notorious adversary within the Sangha, not a bodyguard.

Q 53. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** In the Rig Vedic (Early Vedic) period, the political structure was tribal, and the chief of the tribe (Jana) was known as the Rajan. While the political system was not completely monarchical in the later sense, the office of the Rajan was generally hereditary, usually passing within a specific ruling family, but was also significantly limited by tribal assemblies.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Rajan did not exercise absolute or unrestricted authority. His power was kept in check by several powerful tribal assemblies, most notably the Sabha (a smaller council of elders and elites), the Samiti (a larger, general assembly of the tribe), the Vidatha, and the Gana. Furthermore, he ruled with the assistance of key functionaries like the Purohita (chief priest) and the Senani (military commander), and he did not maintain a regular standing army.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The Samiti was a broad-based tribal assembly that discussed matters of tribal policy and governance. Evidence from the Rig Veda suggests it played a role in the confirmation or ratification of the king, rather than a purely independent election. In practice, kingship had both hereditary and elective elements; the hereditary candidate from the ruling family was likely endorsed or affirmed by the Samiti, ensuring broader tribal consent.

Q 54. Ans. D

Explanation:

- The Milindapanho, meaning the Questions of Milinda, is a Buddhist philosophical text composed in Pali that records a series of intellectual dialogues between the Indo-Greek king Menander I, referred to in the text as Milinda, and the Buddhist monk Nagasena.
- The text is set in the city of Sagala, identified with modern Sialkot in Pakistan, and covers a wide range of Buddhist doctrinal questions, including the nature of the self, rebirth, Nirvana, and the reliability of perception.
- The Milindapanho holds a unique position in Buddhist literature as one of the most sophisticated examples of philosophical debate in the entire Pali canonical and para-canonical tradition and is included in the Pali Canon of the Theravada tradition in Myanmar.
- It is also significant as a historical source because it confirms the existence of Menander as a real historical figure and suggests his genuine engagement with Buddhist thought, which is corroborated by his coinage that uses the Dhamma Chakra symbol.
- A Sanskrit version of the text also exists, but is considered a later adaptation rather than the original composition.

Q 55. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Prayag Prashasti was composed by Harisena, the court poet and minister of Samudragupta. It is written in ornate classical Sanskrit in the prasasti (panegyric) literary tradition and inscribed in the Brahmi script. It stands as one of the finest examples of Gupta-period kavya prose-poetry in epigraphic form.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The inscription is carved on a polished Chunar sandstone pillar originally erected by Mauryan emperor Ashoka. The same pillar also carries Ashokan edicts and a later inscription of Jahangir, making it a multi-layered epigraphic record spanning several centuries and three distinct political regimes.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Prayag Prashasti does mention Vishnugopa of Kanchipuram, identified as a Pallava ruler, but he was not directly annexed into Magadha. Samudragupta's southern campaign followed the policy of "grahana-moksha-anugraha," meaning rulers were captured, made to submit, and then released to continue ruling as subordinates. This was a deliberate political strategy distinct from direct territorial annexation, applied specifically to the distant Dakshinapatha rulers, where permanent administrative integration was impractical. The Pallava kingdom continued to exist as a subordinate political entity, not as an absorbed Gupta province.

Q 56. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Vrajapati:** The Vrajapati was the head of the pasture land. In a predominantly pastoral society where cattle were the chief source of wealth, this was a highly important position. He was responsible for leading the heads of the families (Kulapas) into battle.
- **Kulapa:** The basic unit of Rig Vedic society was the family or Kula. The Kulapa was the eldest male member and the head of the family, holding significant authority over its members.
- **Gramani:** A Grama was originally a tribal fighting unit that later evolved to mean a settled village. Therefore, the Gramani served as the leader of the village or fighting unit.

- **Gana:** The Gana (along with Sardha and Vrata) was a specific type of tribal fighting group or armed assembly among the Early Aryans.

Q 57. Ans. B

Explanation:

- In the Rig Vedic period, Bali referred to the voluntary offerings or tributes presented by the people to the king or tribal chief. These offerings were not regular taxes but were given as a mark of respect and support.
 - ✓ Bhaga later came to denote the king's share of produce or tax.
 - ✓ Kara referred to tax or tribute in later periods.
 - ✓ Hiranya generally meant wealth, gold, or precious objects.

Q 58. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** In the Rig Vedic period, slaves (dasa and dasi) were not mainly used in agricultural or productive activities. They were generally employed for domestic service and household work.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The fourth varna, the Shudras, is mentioned for the first time in the Tenth Mandala (Book) of the Rig Veda, especially in the Purusha Sukta.

Q 59. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Arthashastra dedicates specific sections to the office of the Lakshadhyaksha, the superintendent of the mint, confirming that the Mauryan state exercised strict centralised control over the production of punch-marked silver coins. The state regulated the metal composition, weight standards, and the testing of coins in circulation. Private minting was not permitted, and the state even employed currency examiners called Rupadarshakas to detect and remove counterfeit or debased coins from circulation.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The standard silver Karshapana remained the primary unit of currency throughout the Mauryan period and was

never systematically replaced by gold coins for tax collections. Gold coinage was not a dominant feature of the Mauryan monetary system in the way it later became under the Kushanas and Guptas. Tax assessments and state transactions in the Mauryan system were predominantly conducted in silver, and the Arthashastra consistently references the silver Karshapana as the standard monetary unit for revenue, salaries, fines, and commercial transactions.

- **Statement 3 is correct:** The Kakini was a small fractional copper coin that occupied the lowest denomination in the Mauryan monetary hierarchy. It was used for minor everyday market transactions among ordinary people and artisans. The Arthashastra references smaller denominations below the Karshapana, and the Kakini represents the base unit that made the monetary system accessible for low-value daily exchanges in urban markets and local trade.

Q 60. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The early Indo-Aryans (Vedic people) and the ancient Iranians shared a common linguistic and cultural ancestry, often referred to as the Indo-Iranian heritage. The gradual social stratification seen in the Rig Veda, where a largely egalitarian tribal society began dividing into priests (Brahmanas), warriors (Rajanyas or Kshatriyas), and the common people (Vis) finds a direct and striking parallel in ancient Iranian (Avestan) society.

Q 61. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is true:** Alexander's eastward advance came to a halt at the Hyphasis river, known today as the Beas, in 326 BCE. His soldiers, exhausted after nearly a decade of continuous campaigning across Persia, Central Asia, and the northwestern subcontinent, refused to march any further east. The general Coenus spoke on behalf of the troops and conveyed their collective unwillingness to continue. Alexander, unable to persuade his army, was forced to turn back, marking the easternmost limit of his campaign.

- **Reason (R) is true and correctly explains (A):** Classical sources including Plutarch, Diodorus Siculus, and Curtius Rufus explicitly record that Alexander's soldiers had received detailed reports about the military strength of the Nanda Empire, referred to in Greek sources as the Prasii and Gangaridai. These reports described an enormous standing army consisting of hundreds of thousands of infantry, tens of thousands of cavalry, thousands of war chariots, and a formidable elephant corps numbering in the thousands. The prospect of facing this scale of military force, after years of gruelling warfare and being far from home, was the decisive factor that broke the morale of Alexander's troops and caused the mutiny at the Beas. The fear of the Nanda military machine was therefore the direct and primary cause of the refusal to advance.

Q 62. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Indra was the most important deity in the Rig Veda (with 250 hymns dedicated to him). He was the war-lord who led the Aryan tribes to victory against demons and enemies. He was highly revered as the rain god and as Purandara, which literally translates to the "breaker of forts."
- Agni, the fire god, held the second most important position (with 200 hymns). Fire was considered sacred because it acted as an intermediary between gods and humans.
- Varuna was the third most important Rig Vedic deity. He was the god of water and the personification of the heavens. Crucially, he was revered as the upholder of the natural and cosmic order, known as Rita.
- Soma was considered the god of plants. An intoxicating, sacred drink called soma was named after this deity, prepared from a specific plant found on the Mijavant mountains.

Q 63. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The primary medium of instruction and scholarly debate at Nalanda was Sanskrit, not Pali. Nalanda was a predominantly Mahayana Buddhist institution,

and Mahayana canonical texts, philosophical treatises, and epistemological works were composed and transmitted in Sanskrit. Pali was the scriptural language of the Theravada tradition, which was not the dominant school at Nalanda. Xuanzang's own account of studying texts such as the Yogacarabhumi-shastra under Shilabhadra confirms the Sanskrit scholarly environment that prevailed at the institution.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** Nalanda followed the Panchavidya (five sciences) system, which included Shabdavida (grammar and linguistics), Hetuvidya (logic and dialectics), Chikitsavidya (medicine), Adhyatmavidya (inner science or metaphysical philosophy), and Shilpakarmasthanavidya (arts and crafts).
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Xuanzang records that the revenues from villages granted by successive royal patrons, amounting to over one hundred in number, sustained Nalanda's daily operations. These endowments covered food, clothing, and all residential expenses for the scholarly community. Students and monks were not required to pay for education or boarding, making it entirely grant-supported. The patronage extended from the Gupta period through the Pala dynasty, as confirmed by epigraphic and textual evidence.

Q 64. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Mahabhashya, meaning the Great Commentary, was composed by Patanjali around the 2nd century BCE and serves as an elaborate critical commentary on Panini's Ashtadhyayi and on the Varttikas, the supplementary rules added by the grammarian Katyayana to Panini's original system.
- Where Panini's sutras are extremely condensed and cryptic by design, Patanjali's Mahabhashya unpacks, explains, debates, and sometimes challenges these rules through extended philosophical and linguistic discussion.
- Patanjali does not merely explain Panini passively but actively engages with Katyayana's criticisms of Panini and defends or modifies positions through logical argument, making the Mahabhashya a work of independent intellectual depth rather than a simple explanatory gloss.

- Together, Panini's Ashtadhyayi, Katyayana's Varttikas, and Patanjali's Mahabhashya form what the Sanskrit grammatical tradition calls the Trimurti of Sanskrit grammar, the three foundational authorities of the entire discipline.
- Beyond its grammatical significance, the Mahabhashya is also a valuable historical source because Patanjali makes incidental references to contemporary political events, social conditions, and geographical realities of his time, including references to Greek invasions of Indian cities, providing historians with important evidence for reconstructing the political world of the post-Mauryan period.

Q 65. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Karnasuvarna was the capital of Shashanka, the ruler of Gauda, who was a contemporary and rival of Emperor Harsha in the early 7th century CE.
- The archaeological remains of Karnasuvarna are identified with the site of Rajbadidanga near Murshidabad in present-day West Bengal.
- Shashanka is historically significant as one of the first independent rulers to unite Bengal as a distinct political entity and is the earliest known major ruler of the Gauda kingdom.
- Xuanzang visited the region during his travels and left descriptions of the area, and Shashanka is notably criticised in Buddhist sources for his hostility toward Buddhism, including the alleged destruction of the Bodhi tree at Bodhi Gaya and persecution of Buddhist monks.
- His kingdom of Gauda, centred on Karnasuvarna, controlled a substantial portion of Bengal and parts of Odisha before its eventual decline following Shashanka's death around 637 CE, after which the region entered a period of political fragmentation that preceded the rise of the Pala dynasty.

Q 66. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Uraiyur:** Uraiyur, located near modern Tiruchirappalli, served as the early capital of the Chola kingdom and was a major inland centre of the cotton textile trade. Sangam texts

specifically identify Uraiyur as a hub for cloth production and trade, and Roman sources corroborate the export of fine Indian cotton textiles from this region.

- **Puhar:** Puhar, also known as Kaveripattinam, was the principal port city of the early Cholas and one of the most active centres of Indo-Roman maritime trade during the Sangam period. Archaeological excavations at Arikamedu nearby have yielded Roman amphorae, rouletted ware, and other imported goods, confirming the intensity of Roman commercial contact along this stretch of the Coromandel coast.
- **Karikala:** Karikala is the most celebrated ruler of the early Chola Sangam period. The Sangam text Pattinappalai credits him with constructing an embankment along the Kaveri river to control flooding and channel water for irrigation, a significant feat of hydraulic engineering that expanded agricultural productivity in the Kaveri delta region.
- **Elara:** Elara was a Chola ruler who crossed over to Sri Lanka and ruled it for approximately 44 years, as recorded in the Sinhalese chronicle Mahavamsa. He is described in the Mahavamsa itself as a just and able ruler despite being a foreign conqueror, and was eventually defeated by the Sinhalese prince Dutugamunu, which ended Chola control over the island.

Q 67. Ans. D

Explanation:

- In the Rigveda, the Maruts are described as the gods of storms and winds.
- They are often portrayed as fierce and youthful deities accompanying Indra, the god of thunder and rain.
- The Maruts were associated with:
 - ✓ Thunderstorms
 - ✓ Strong winds
 - ✓ Lightning and rain

Q 68. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Sangam poetry is organised around five distinct ecological zones called Tinai, each associated with a specific landscape, season, flower, deity, and human emotional theme.

- Marutam refers to the fertile agricultural plains watered by rivers, and its associated human theme is the infidelity of the lover and the patient suffering of the heroine.
- The Marutam landscape is characterised by paddy cultivation, river banks, water buffaloes, and settled agrarian communities, making it the Tinai most directly linked with organised farming and riverine agricultural life.
- The other four Tinai are Kurinji, associated with mountainous terrain and the theme of premarital love; Mullai, associated with forest and pastoral landscapes and the theme of patient waiting; Neytal, associated with coastal and seashore landscapes and the theme of anxious longing; and Palai, associated with arid desert terrain and the theme of separation during a journey.
- A sixth category called Palai is sometimes treated as a derivative of Kurinji and Mullai rather than an independent landscape.
- This five-Tinai framework, called Akattinai, is systematically codified in the Tolkappiyam and forms the structural backbone of all classical Sangam akam poetry.

Q 69. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Assertion is true:** Vikramshila was founded by the Pala ruler Dharmapala in the late 8th to early 9th century CE. Under sustained Pala patronage and through the presence of eminent Vajrayana masters, including Atisha Dipankara Shrijnana, it developed into the foremost institutional centre of Vajrayana and Tantric Buddhist learning in eastern India, gradually eclipsing Nalanda in this specific domain. Taranatha's account and Tibetan Buddhist historiographical sources consistently identify Vikramshila as the preeminent Vajrayana seat of the Pala period.
- **Reason is true:** Vikramshila maintained a structured academic administration that included a panel of six eminent scholars (dvapanditas) stationed at its gates to examine aspirants, and the institution conferred the formal title of Pandita upon scholars who successfully completed rigorous training and examination.
- **Why (R) does not explain (A):** Vikramshila's supremacy in Vajrayana Buddhism resulted

from its specialised Tantric curriculum, the doctrinal orientation of its faculty, and the active patronage of Pala rulers who were themselves committed Vajrayana practitioners. The degree-conferring mechanism and the Pandita title were administrative features common to major monastic universities of the period and did not causally determine Vikramshila's doctrinal specialisation in Vajrayana over Nalanda.

Q 70. Ans. B

Explanation:

- D.D. Kosambi conducted a systematic analysis of Mauryan punch-marked silver coins and observed a progressive decline in their silver content over time, indicating deliberate debasement by mixing increasing proportions of base metals into the alloy.
- He interpreted this as direct material evidence of severe fiscal stress in the later Mauryan state, which was struggling to sustain the enormous expenditure of maintaining a large standing army, an extensive bureaucracy, and a vast administrative network.
- Kosambi connected this financial exhaustion to the broader process of Mauryan imperial decline, arguing that the state's weakening economic base directly undermined its capacity to hold its vast territories together.

Q 71. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The Puranic texts do not celebrate Mahapadma Nanda as a legitimate Kshatriya descendant. On the contrary, the Puranas are deeply hostile toward the Nandas and describe Mahapadma as being of low-born origin, specifically as the son of a Shudra mother by a Kshatriya father, making him illegitimate by Brahmanical social standards. The Puranas characterise him as a destroyer of all Kshatriyas and use the epithet Sarvakshatrantaka, meaning the annihilator of the Kshatriya order, reflecting Brahmanical resentment toward a ruler they considered of impure lineage seizing imperial power.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Mahapadma Nanda pursued an aggressive policy of territorial

expansion and systematically conquered surrounding kingdoms, including Kalinga, Koshala, and several others, effectively dismantling the older Kshatriya ruling houses of northern India. Following these conquests, the Puranas attribute to him the sovereign title Ekarat, meaning the sole ruler or the one king, signifying his claim to paramount political authority over the entire subcontinent as the undisputed paramount power.

- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Megasthenes was not a contemporary of Mahapadma Nanda. He served as the Seleucid ambassador to the court of Chandragupta Maurya, who had already overthrown the Nanda dynasty around 321 BCE. Megasthenes arrived at Pataliputra well after the Nandas had ceased to exist. He therefore had no direct encounter with any Nanda ruler, including Mahapadma Nanda.

Q 72. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The Mudrarakshasa deals with Chanakya's political strategy to consolidate Chandragupta's imperial position by bringing Rakshasa, the former Nanda minister, into Mauryan service. The marriage alliance referenced in the text is between Chandragupta and the daughter of Parvataka, the Himalayan king ally, not a Greek princess. The marriage between Chandragupta and a Seleucid Greek princess is attested in classical Greek and Latin sources in connection with the treaty between Chandragupta and Seleucus Nicator, but this event does not appear in the Mudrarakshasa.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Mrichchhakatika, meaning The Little Clay Cart, composed by Shudraka, narrates the love story of Charudatta, an impoverished but noble Brahmin merchant of Ujjain, and Vasantasena, a wealthy and accomplished courtesan. It is notable for its realistic portrayal of urban social life, its non-royal protagonists, and its inclusion of a political subplot involving the overthrow of the corrupt king Palaka, making it thematically richer and socially broader than most Sanskrit dramas.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The Mudrarakshasa is entirely centred on political intrigue and statecraft, with Chanakya, Rakshasa, and

Chandragupta as its principal characters. Unlike most Sanskrit dramatic convention which typically features a romantic heroine as a central figure, the Mudrarakshasa is an exception in the classical Sanskrit dramatic tradition for its complete absence of a female main character.

Q 73. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Panchatantra, attributed to Vishnu Sharma, is a Sanskrit collection of interconnected animal fables composed to teach Niti (wise conduct, statecraft, and practical wisdom) to three princes of King Amarasakti of Mahilaropya. The frame story states it was designed to educate the princes within six months through narrative pedagogy rather than an abstract treatise.
- It consists of five books (tantras): Mitra-bheda (separation of friends), Mitra-samprapti (gaining of friends), Kakolukiya (war and diplomacy), Labdhapranasham (loss of gains), and Aparikshitakaraka (hasty action). Each section presents aspects of political and social wisdom through embedded stories within a frame narrative.
- It draws from the Arthashastra tradition of Niti literature and shares conceptual links with Kautilya's political thought, presenting ideas through narrative form. It belongs to the Nitishastra genre and is related to the later Hitopadesa of Narayana, which reorganised Panchatantra material for pedagogical clarity.
- It was translated into Pahlavi in the 6th century CE under Sassanid ruler Khusrow I by physician Burzoe. This led to the Arabic version Kalila wa Dimna by Ibn al-Muqaffa in the 8th century CE, which spread across the Islamic world and medieval Europe. Over 200 versions exist in more than 50 languages, making it one of the most widely diffused works of Indian literary origin.

Q 74. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** According to the text, it is the Yajur Veda that contains hymns and their accompanying rituals. The Atharva Veda contains charms and spells to ward off evils and diseases.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** The text explicitly states that the Vedic Samhitas were followed by the Brahmanas, which are full of ritualistic formulae and explain the social and religious aspects of rituals.

Q 75. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Nagarjuna, who flourished around the 2nd century CE and is associated with the Satavahana court in the Deccan, is the single most important philosopher in the history of Mahayana Buddhism after the Buddha himself.
- His foundational work, the Mulamadhyamakakarika, systematically articulated the doctrine of Shunyata, meaning emptiness, which holds that all phenomena are devoid of any fixed, independent, or inherent existence and arise only through dependent origination. This philosophical position became the cornerstone of the Madhyamaka school, one of the two principal philosophical traditions of Mahayana Buddhism alongside the Yogachara school of Vasubandhu and Asanga.
- Nagarjuna's influence extended far beyond India into Tibet, China, Korea, and Japan, where his Madhyamaka philosophy shaped the development of Buddhist thought across all of East and Central Asia.
- He also authored the Vigrahavyavartani, the Ratnavali, and the Suhrillekha, among other works.
- A secondary tradition in Indian Rasashastra alchemical literature associates a figure named Nagarjuna with texts on mercury processing and metallurgical techniques, but historians debate whether this is the same individual or a later figure who adopted the prestigious name.

Q 76. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** Dakshinapatha in ancient texts carried a dual meaning. It referred simultaneously to a geographical region broadly corresponding to the Deccan and to the overland trade route connecting the Gangetic north with the south. Its territorial boundaries were never fixed, as it lay completely south of the Vindhyas. Several ancient sources place regions

like Vidarbha and parts of central India within the Dakshinapatha zone, and the Arthashastra uses the term primarily in the context of a southern route rather than a strictly demarcated geographical region with the Vindhyas as an absolute northern boundary.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** Dakshinapatha functioned as one of the most important overland trade arteries of ancient India, connecting major Gangetic urban centres such as Pataliputra, Varanasi, and Kaushambi with the markets and ports of the Deccan and further south. Control over this route was economically and politically decisive, which is why successive powers, including the Mauryas and Satavahanas, prioritised its administration.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The Satavahana rulers explicitly used the title Dakshinapathasvami, meaning lord of Dakshinapatha, in their inscriptions and records. This title reflects both their territorial control over the Deccan region and their authority over the commercially vital southern trade route, underscoring how central Dakshinapatha was to Satavahana political identity and legitimacy.

Q 77. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Lotsawa is the Tibetan term meaning “translator” and was the designation given to Tibetan scholars who travelled to Indian monastic universities such as Nalanda, Vikramshila, and Jagaddala to master Sanskrit and collaborate with Indian Panditas in translating Mahayana and Vajrayana texts into Tibetan. Their work formed the textual foundation of the Tibetan Buddhist canon, the Kangyur and Tengyur.
- Pandita was the title conferred upon accomplished Indian scholars.
- Mahasiddhas were realised Tantric adepts.
- Taranatha was a specific 16th to 17th-century Tibetan historian.

Q 78. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The Painted Grey Ware (PGW) is most closely associated with the Later Vedic period (c. 1000–600 BCE) in northern India.

- **Characteristics:** It is a fine, wheel-made pottery with a smooth grey surface painted with black geometric designs.
- **Distribution:** It is widely found in the Ganga-Yamuna Doab, including sites like Hastinapur, Ahichhatra, and Kaushambi.
- **Significance:** These sites mark a definitive shift away from the semi-nomadic pastoralism of the Early Vedic period toward settled agricultural communities. While these settlements provided the material basis for future state formation, they remained essentially rural in character; the “Second Urbanisation” only began later with the NBPW phase.

Q 79. Ans. D

Explanation:

- According to Tamil literary tradition, the three Sangam assemblies were convened and patronised exclusively by the Pandya kings of Madurai.
- The First Sangam was held at Madurai, the Second Sangam at Kapadapuram, and the Third Sangam again at Madurai.
- All three assemblies were conducted under Pandya royal patronage, making the dynasty uniquely significant in the history of Tamil literary culture.
- The city of Madurai, the Pandya capital, functioned as the central institutional home of Tamil literary scholarship across all three legendary assemblies.
- The Cholas were associated with the eastern Coromandel coast and their capital, Uraiyur and Puhar, the Cheras with the western Kerala region, and the Pallavas were a later dynasty that rose to prominence only after the Sangam age had concluded.

Q 80. Ans. A

Explanation:

- The primitive towns of the Later Vedic period are associated with the growth of early settlements in the Ganga–Yamuna doab, especially linked with the Painted Grey Ware culture.
- These sites show early signs of:
 - ✓ Permanent settlements
 - ✓ Mud houses and simple planning

- ✓ Craft activities
- ✓ Transition from rural to semi-urban life
- **Hastinapur and Kausambi**
 - ✓ Hastinapur shows PGW levels with early habitation and limited urban features.
 - ✓ Kaushambi developed as an important early centre of trade and settlement growth.

Q 81. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **The Assertion is true:** Gondophernes is a historically verified Indo-Parthian king whose existence is confirmed through coins and inscriptions. According to early Christian tradition, specifically the apocryphal Acts of Thomas, the Apostle Thomas travelled to the court of Gondophernes to preach Christianity. This tradition forms the basis of the association between Gondophernes and the early arrival of Christianity in the Indian subcontinent.
- **The Reason is false:** The Takht-i-Bahi inscription (found near modern-day Peshawar, Pakistan) is a crucial historical artefact because it proves that Gondophernes was a real historical figure, dating his 26th regnal year to 46 CE. However, the inscription does not record his conversion to Christianity. It is merely a dedicatory inscription marking the construction of a Buddhist site (or secular monument) by a local official. There is no epigraphical evidence in this inscription or any other that Gondophernes actually converted to the Christian faith.

Q 82. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Hemchandra Raychaudhuri argued that Ashoka's deep personal commitment to ahimsa and the abandonment of aggressive military policy following the Kalinga war in 261 BCE had a directly debilitating effect on Mauryan military strength.
- Raychaudhuri contended that Ashoka's propagation of dhamma, with its emphasis on non-violence, compassion, and the renunciation of conquest, eroded the offensive military culture that had built and sustained the empire under Chandragupta Maurya and Bindusara.
- The professional soldier class, which depended

on active campaigns for rewards, plunder, and prestige, found itself without purpose in an imperial system that had ideologically renounced war.

- This argument made Ashoka's pacifism a direct structural cause of military decline, leaving the empire increasingly unable to defend its vast frontiers against external pressures, particularly from the northwest.
- But historians such as Romila Thapar counter that the empire's decline was rooted in economic and administrative factors rather than in any single ruler's ideological choices.

Q 83. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Panchasiddhantika is an important astronomical text in which Varahamihira summarised and compared five earlier astronomical systems: the Paulisha Siddhanta, Romaka Siddhanta, Vasishtha Siddhanta, Saura Siddhanta, and Paitamaha Siddhanta. Among these, the Paulisha and Romaka Siddhantas are recognised by scholars as showing Greek and Hellenistic influences. These influences entered Indian astronomy through long-term contact after Alexander's campaigns and later Indo-Greek interactions. Thus, the Panchasiddhantika served both to preserve earlier astronomical knowledge and to compare different astronomical traditions known during Varahamihira's time.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Varahamihira did not reject the idea that planetary movements affect earthly events. Instead, he supported and developed this idea. His Brihat Samhita contains many chapters on planetary omens, atmospheric changes, rainfall prediction based on celestial observations, and the interpretation of natural signs for agriculture and political forecasting. His Brihat Jataka is completely devoted to horoscopic astrology. Varahamihira consistently believed that celestial movements were connected to earthly events.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The Brihat Samhita is a wide-ranging encyclopaedic work that covers many subjects beyond astronomy and includes knowledge useful for administration and daily life. It contains chapters on architecture and

town planning, gemology (testing precious stones), botany and cultivation of plants, perfumery, meteorology, water-divining, planetary movements, natural omens, and seasonal agricultural guidance. Because of this wide scope, the Brihat Samhita is considered one of the most important encyclopaedic works of the Gupta period and an important source for understanding the scientific and material culture of early medieval India.

Q 84. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The Pathinenkilkanakku, meaning the Eighteen Lower Works, is a collection of post-Sangam didactic texts that marks a clear thematic shift away from the akam and puram poetry of the earlier Melkanakku corpus. Where the Melkanakku texts dealt primarily with love, heroism, war, and death, the Kilkanakku texts are predominantly concerned with ethics, moral conduct, right living, and practical wisdom for everyday social life.
- The Tirukkural is the most celebrated text of this collection and exemplifies this didactic character through its 1,330 couplets organised under the three books of Aram (virtue), Porul (polity and material life), and Inbam (love).
- Other texts of the Kilkanakku, such as the Naladiyar, Pazhamozhi Nanuru, and Inna Narpathu similarly deal with moral maxims, social conduct, and practical ethics. The shift from heroic and romantic poetry to moral and didactic literature in the Kilkanakku texts broadly reflects the changing social and religious environment of the post-Sangam period, when Jain and Buddhist ethical influences were actively shaping Tamil intellectual culture.

Q 85. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Banskhera copper plate inscription of Harshavardhana, dated to his 22nd regnal year, records the grant of a village to a Brahmin donee. It is notable beyond its content because it carries Harsha's personal signature, making it one of the rare ancient Indian inscriptions that preserves the autograph of the issuing ruler himself.

- The inscription follows the standard format of early medieval land grant charters, specifying the boundaries of the donated land, the fiscal and administrative immunities transferred to the donee, and the witnesses to the transaction.
- The Banskhera and Madhuban copper plate inscriptions together are the primary epigraphic sources for Harsha's land grant activity and provide important evidence for the administrative and agrarian practices of the Pushyabhuti dynasty.

Q 86. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The conflict between Ajatashatru of Magadha and Prasenajit of Kosala was a prolonged and complex struggle rooted in competing claims over the wealthy territory of Kashi, which had already been a contested zone between the two powers during the reign of Ajatashatru's father, Bimbisara.
- Buddhist texts, including the Samyutta Nikaya, record multiple engagements between the two kingdoms.
- The conflict was eventually resolved through a diplomatic settlement sealed by a matrimonial alliance in which Ajatashatru married a Kosalan princess, the daughter of Prasenajit. As part of this settlement, the prosperous territory of Kashi was formally transferred to Magadha as dowry.
- The absorption of Kashi was a decisive geopolitical gain because Kashi was one of the wealthiest urban and commercial centres of the Gangetic plains, and its incorporation significantly expanded Magadha's revenue base, population, and territorial reach westward.
- This consolidation positioned Magadha as the dominant power of the entire middle Gangetic region and laid the strategic foundation for its subsequent expansion under the Shishunaga and Nanda dynasties.

Q 87. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** The Bodhisattva Padmapani, depicted holding a blue lotus, is one of the most celebrated paintings in the

entire history of Indian art and is located in Cave 1 at Ajanta. It dates to the Vakataka period of the 5th to 6th century CE and is renowned for its technical mastery, emotional depth, and the characteristic Ajanta technique of shading to create a three-dimensional sculptural effect on a flat painted surface.

- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** The Bagh cave paintings in Madhya Pradesh are distinctive within the tradition of ancient Indian cave painting precisely because they emphasise secular themes such as court processions, musicians, dancers, and festive celebrations, setting them apart from the predominantly religious Buddhist narrative content of the Ajanta paintings. This secular orientation makes Bagh an important comparative case in the study of Gupta-period painting traditions.
- **Pair 3 is incorrectly matched:** The painting of the Dying Princess, depicting the grief-stricken scene of Nanda's wife, Sundari, fainting upon hearing of Nanda's impending renunciation, is correctly located in Ajanta Cave 16. However, it belongs to the Vakataka period of the 5th to 6th century CE, not the Mauryan period. Attributing this painting to the Mauryan period is a chronological error of nearly eight centuries.

Q 88. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Odantapuri was founded by Gopala, the first ruler of the Pala dynasty, around the mid-8th century CE, making it among the earliest state-sponsored monastic universities of the Pala period. It was located in Magadha, in the region corresponding to modern Bihar. Odantapuri is considered the institutional precursor that established the Pala tradition of royal patronage for large-scale monastic education, a pattern that Gopala's successors replicated at Vikramshila, Jagaddala, and other centres.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** According to Tibetan records, Odantapuri was situated on a mountain called Hiranya Parvat by the bank of the river Panchanan. It housed approximately 12,000 students at its peak and corresponds to present-day Bihar Sharif, the headquarters of the modern Nalanda district.

- **Statement 3 is correct:** When the Tibetan king Trisong Detsen commissioned the construction of Samye, Tibet's first Buddhist monastery, around 779 CE, the architectural layout and institutional organisation of Odantapuri served as its direct model. Shantarakshita, the Nalanda-trained abbot who oversaw Samye's establishment, was instrumental in transmitting this institutional template to Tibet. Samye thus replicated Odantapuri's spatial arrangement of a central shrine surrounded by subsidiary structures, encoding the Indian monastic university model into the earliest phase of organised Tibetan Buddhist institutional life. This connection makes Odantapuri disproportionately significant in the history of Buddhist transmission relative to its comparatively modest scholarly profile in India itself.

Q 89. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The transition from the Early Rig Vedic economy to the Later Vedic economy marks a significant shift in livelihood patterns.
- **Key characteristics:**
 - ✓ In the Rig Vedic period, society was largely semi-nomadic and pastoral, with cattle rearing as the primary economic activity.
 - ✓ In the Later Vedic period, there was a clear movement towards settled agriculture, especially in the Ganga-Yamuna doab region, supported by better knowledge of iron tools and expanded cultivation.

Q 90. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** Elephants were never used for rapid long-distance communications in any ancient Indian military tradition, and desert terrain was entirely unsuited to elephant deployment. In the Magadhan military system, elephants functioned as frontline assault weapons. Their primary battlefield roles were breaking enemy infantry formations, demolishing fortification gates, carrying armed warriors into battle from elevated platforms called howdahs, and creating psychological terror among opposing forces and their horses.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Greek accounts preserved by Plutarch, Diodorus, and Curtius Rufus describe the Nanda military as maintaining all four traditional components of ancient Indian warfare simultaneously, meaning infantry, cavalry, chariots, and elephants, in exceptionally large numbers.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Magadha's elephants were sourced from the densely forested regions to its east and northeast, specifically the forests of Bengal, Odisha, and the Vindhya-Satpura belt, all of which were rich in wild elephant populations. Gandhara in the northwest was an arid and mountainous region ecologically unsuitable for elephant habitation and was never identified as an elephant-supplying zone.
- **Core philosophical outlook of the Upanishads:**
 - ✓ The Upanishads emphasise inner spiritual inquiry, self-knowledge, and the search for the ultimate reality.
 - ✓ They shift the focus from external rituals to understanding the nature of:
 - ✓ the self (Atman), the universal reality (Brahman)
 - ✓ The ultimate goal is achieving spiritual liberation (moksha) through wisdom and realisation.
 - ✓ The texts are therefore considered the philosophical culmination of Vedic literature and are called Vedanta, meaning "the end of the Vedas."

Q 91. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Gargi Vachaknavi**
 - ✓ A renowned philosopher mentioned in the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad.
 - ✓ She famously debated Yajnavalkya on the nature of Atman and Brahman in King Janaka's court.
- **Maitreyi**
 - ✓ Also mentioned in the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad.
 - ✓ She rejected material wealth in favour of spiritual knowledge (Brahma-vidya).
 - ✓ Known for her profound discussion on the transience of worldly possessions.
- **Lopamudra**
 - ✓ A Rigvedic seer and poetess.
 - ✓ Associated with hymns in the Rigveda, reflecting devotion and philosophical depth.
- **Vishwavara**
 - ✓ Early Rigvedic female seeress.
 - ✓ Composed hymns that are respected for their spiritual and intellectual depth.

Q 92. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The Upanishads mark a major transformation in ancient Indian thought. They were composed during a period when people began questioning the dominance of elaborate Vedic rituals and sacrifices.

Q 93. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Pushyamitra Shunga was the Senapati (commander-in-chief) of the Mauryan army under the last Mauryan ruler Brihadratha. Around 185 BCE, he assassinated Brihadratha during a military parade or review, usurped the throne, and established the Shunga dynasty. This event is recorded in the Divyavadana and the Puranic dynastic lists, which mark it as the end of Mauryan imperial rule.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Patanjali, the celebrated grammarian and author of the Mahabhashya, a commentary on Panini's Ashtadhyayi, is traditionally associated with Pushyamitra Shunga as his court scholar. The Mahabhashya itself contains a reference to the Ashvamedha performed by Pushyamitra, and later tradition identifies Patanjali as the officiating priest at both sacrifices. The performance of two Ashvamedha sacrifices by Pushyamitra is additionally corroborated by Kalidasa's Malavikagnimitra, which depicts the Shunga court and references the Ashvamedha horse being guarded from rival claimants.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** While Buddhist texts like the Ashokavadana and Divyavadana portray Pushyamitra Shunga as a cruel persecutor of Buddhists who destroyed monasteries, archaeological evidence proves that during the Shunga period, the Great Stupa at Sanchi actually underwent significant structural expansion. The original brick stupa built by

Ashoka was nearly doubled in size, encased in stone slabs, and a stone balustrade (railing) was added. While this expansion may have been funded by wealthy merchants and local donors rather than royal decree, Pushyamitra did not prohibit its expansion. In fact, the Shunga era is known for substantial additions to both the Sanchi and Bharhut stupas.

Q 94. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Videha was an important ancient kingdom located in the northern plains of present-day Bihar.
 - ✓ Historical accounts place it north of the Ganga River during the Early Vedic period.
 - ✓ The kingdom is closely associated with King Janaka, who is described in ancient Indian texts as the father of Princess Sita, the heroine of the Ramayana.
 - ✓ Videha also emerged as an important centre of Vedic learning and philosophical discussions during later periods.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Videha did not remain an independent monarchy. By the 6th century BCE, the monarchical rule in Videha had declined, and it was absorbed into the Vrijji Confederacy (Vajji Sangha). This confederacy was a powerful oligarchic league of eight clans, among which the Licchavis of Vaishali were the most dominant. Vaishali served as the administrative and political centre of the entire confederacy, rather than being replaced by it.

Q 95. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Aihole inscription, dated to 634 CE, was composed by Ravikirti, the court poet of Pulakeshin II, in ornate classical Sanskrit. It is a prasasti celebrating Pulakeshin II's achievements and is the primary epigraphic source for the conflict between Harsha and Pulakeshin II. Ravikirti explicitly compares himself to Kalidasa and Bharavi in the inscription, reflecting the high literary self-consciousness of Chalukya court culture.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The boundary fixed between Harsha's northern empire and

Pulakeshin II's Chalukya kingdom was the Narmada River, not the Godavari. The Narmada functioned as the conventional geopolitical frontier between the northern and Deccan political zones throughout this period. The Godavari River was well within the Deccan and deep inside the Chalukya-controlled territory.

- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Bhaskaravarman of Kamarupa was consistently a loyal ally of Harsha, particularly in campaigns against Shashanka of Gauda. Harsha lost purely due to the superior Chalukyan elephant divisions.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** Following his successful repulsion of Harsha's southward advance across the Narmada, Pulakeshin II assumed the title Parameshwara, meaning supreme lord, to celebrate his achievement of stopping the most powerful northern emperor of the age. The Aihole inscription records this claim and the victory itself, cementing Pulakeshin II's status as the preeminent ruler of peninsular India at that moment.

Q 96. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Ashvamedha**
 - ✓ The Ashvamedha was a horse sacrifice ritual symbolizing royal power and territorial expansion.
 - ✓ It also had strong fertility symbolism, where the queen's ritual participation represented earth's prosperity.
- **Rajasuya**
 - ✓ The Rajasuya was a royal consecration ceremony performed to legitimize the authority of a king.
 - ✓ It marked the formal establishment of kingship.
- **Vajapeya**
 - ✓ The Vajapeya was a prestigious ritual involving chariot races and communal participation.
 - ✓ It symbolized social status, prestige, and ritual supremacy.
- **Atharvan tradition**
 - ✓ The Atharvan (Atharvaveda) tradition included magical spells, healing rituals, and fertility rites.
 - ✓ It reflects the assimilation of folk and non-Aryan beliefs into Vedic religion.

Q 97. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Vagbhata, who flourished around the 7th century CE and is associated with the Sindh region, composed the Ashtanga Hridaya, meaning the Heart of the Eight Limbs, as a systematic and comprehensive synthesis of the earlier classical Ayurvedic tradition.
- The text drew primarily from the two foundational pillars of classical Ayurveda, the Charaka Samhita dealing with internal medicine and the Sushruta Samhita dealing with surgery, and condensed their vast content into a more accessible and systematically organised form.
- The eight branches of Ayurveda that the text covers are Kayachikitsa (general internal medicine), Balachikitsa (paediatrics), Graha Chikitsa (psychiatry and disorders attributed to supernatural causes), Urdhvanga Chikitsa (diseases of the head, eyes, ears, nose, and throat), Shalya Tantra (surgery), Damstra Chikitsa (toxicology), Jara Chikitsa (geriatrics and rejuvenation), and Vrisha Chikitsa (reproductive medicine and virility).
- The Ashtanga Hridaya became one of the three canonical texts of classical Ayurveda, collectively known as the Brihat Trayi or the Great Triad alongside the Charaka Samhita and Sushruta Samhita. It was later translated into Tibetan and Arabic, making it a significant text in the international transmission of Indian medical knowledge.

Q 98. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Manimekalai was composed by Sattanar, also referred to as Merchant Sattanar, reflecting his background as a grain merchant from Madurai.
- The text functions as a sequel to the Shilappadikaram and follows Manimekalai, the daughter of Kovalan and the courtesan Madhavi, as she renounces worldly life and embraces Buddhist philosophy.
- It is the only surviving Tamil Buddhist epic and is an important source for understanding the presence and influence of Buddhism in early Tamil society.
- Ilango Adigal authored the Shilappadikaram.

- Tiruvalluvar authored the Tirukkural.
- Nakkirar was a prominent Sangam poet and literary critic associated with the Third Sangam.

Q 99. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is true:** The Lauriya Nandangarh pillar, located in the West Champaran district of Bihar, is one of the best-preserved Ashokan pillars and is crowned with a single lion capital, distinguishing it from the more famous four-lion capital at Sarnath. However, the lion at Lauriya Nandangarh is more precisely described as a single standing lion.
- **Reason (R) is false:** Ashokan pillar shafts were monolithic, meaning each shaft was carved from a single continuous piece of Chunar sandstone quarried in Uttar Pradesh and transported hundreds of kilometres to their installation sites. The seamless, jointless construction of these shafts, combined with their characteristic mirror-like polish, is precisely what makes them extraordinary. They were never assembled from stacked cylindrical blocks.

Q 100. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Shatapatha Brahmana is one of the most important Brahmana texts of Vedic literature.
- It gives elaborate accounts of several major Vedic rituals and sacrifices, including:
 - ✓ Ashvamedha (horse sacrifice)
 - ✓ Rajasuya (royal consecration ritual)
 - ✓ Agnicayana (construction of the sacred fire altar)
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Shatapatha Brahmana belongs to the Vedic Brahmanical tradition, not the Buddhist tradition.
- Its primary focus is on:
 - ✓ yajnas and sacrificial rituals
 - ✓ royal ceremonies
 - ✓ fire worship
 - ✓ maintenance of cosmic order through rituals
- Buddhism later emerged partly in response to excessive ritualism found in Vedic traditions.

Q 101. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** Tolkappiyam is the oldest surviving Tamil grammatical treatise. According to Tamil literary tradition, it was composed by Tolkappiyar, a disciple of the sage Agastya, and is traditionally associated with the Second Sangam. It deals not only with grammar and phonology but also with poetics and human behaviour, making it a foundational text of the entire Tamil literary tradition.
- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** Shilappadikaram, composed by Ilango Adigal, narrates the story of Kovalan and Kannagi. Kovalan is wrongly executed by the Pandyan king of Madurai on a false charge of theft. Kannagi, devastated and enraged, tears off her own anklet to prove his innocence before the king, who dies of shock upon realising his error. Kannagi then curses the city of Madurai, which is consumed by fire. The epic is a powerful narrative of wifely devotion, royal injustice, and divine retribution.
- **Pair 3 is incorrectly matched:** Manimekalai is a Buddhist text, not a Jain one. Composed by Sattanar, it functions as a sequel to Shilappadikaram and follows Manimekalai, the daughter of Kovalan and the courtesan Madhavi, as she renounces worldly life and embraces Buddhist philosophy. It is one of the most important texts for understanding the spread of Buddhism in early Tamil society.
- **Pair 4 is incorrectly matched:** The Tirukkural, composed by Thiruvalluvar, is a universal philosophical and ethical text organised into three books covering Aram (virtue and ethics), Porul (polity and material life), and Inbam (love). It has no association with military strategies or with the Chola kings specifically. It is among the most widely translated works of classical Indian literature and is revered across religious and linguistic boundaries.

Q 102. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Licchavis of Vesali and Sakyas of Kapilavastu: Both of these powerful clans were among the original eight recipients of the Buddha's bodily relics. The other six who received the primary bodily relics were:

- ✓ Ajatasatru (King of Magadha)
- ✓ The Bulis of Allakappa
- ✓ The Koliyas of Ramagrama
- ✓ The Mallas of Pava
- ✓ The Mallas of Kusinara
- ✓ A Brahmin of Vethadipa

- **Moriyas of Pipphalivana:** According to the Mahaparinibbana Sutta, the Moriyas of Pipphalivana arrived late, after the bodily relics had already been distributed. However, they successfully claimed the embers (ashes) from the cremation pyre and built a stupa over them in their territory.
- The Brahmin who mediated the dispute and divided the relics was named Dona (Drona). He kept the urn used to measure the relics and built a stupa over it, which means a total of 10 stupas were originally built: 8 over bodily relics, 1 over ashes, and 1 over the urn!

Q 103. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Kiratarjuniya, composed by the Sanskrit poet Bharavi around the 7th century CE, is one of the six classical Sanskrit mahakavyas and is celebrated as one of the most technically accomplished works in the entire Sanskrit literary tradition.
- The poem is based on an episode from the Vana Parva of the Mahabharata in which the Pandava hero Arjuna performs intense penance in the Himalayan forests to obtain the Pashupatastra, the devastating weapon of Lord Shiva, which the Pandavas needed to eventually defeat the Kauravas.
- Shiva, wishing to test Arjuna's worthiness before granting the weapon, disguises himself as a Kirata, meaning a mountain-dwelling hunter, accompanied by his consort Parvati, similarly disguised. A fierce combat breaks out between Arjuna and the disguised Shiva over the killing of a demon named Muka, who had attacked Arjuna in the form of a wild boar. Arjuna fights with extraordinary valour but is ultimately defeated. Shiva then reveals his true divine form, acknowledges Arjuna's exceptional courage and devotion, and grants him the Pashupatastra.
- The poem spans 18 cantos and is renowned in Sanskrit literary criticism for the density and

complexity of its verse, particularly its 18th canto, which is celebrated for its extraordinary technical virtuosity in manipulating sound, metre, and meaning simultaneously.

- Bharavi's style is characterised by the quality called *artha gaurava*, meaning depth and weightiness of meaning, for which he is specifically praised in the tradition of Sanskrit literary criticism.

Q 104. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** Suvarnagiri was the provincial capital of the southern province of Dakshinapatha, not Uttarapatha. The provincial headquarters of the Uttarapatha region under the Mauryas was Taxila, which served as the administrative and commercial nerve centre of the entire northwest.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Pushyabhuti dynasty, based at Sthanvishvara near modern Thaneshwar in Haryana, controlled a strategically critical stretch of the Uttarapatha corridor. This control gave them privileged access to the horse trade flowing in from Central Asia and the northwestern frontier, which was economically and militarily significant since horses were indispensable for maintaining cavalry strength. This commercial and strategic dominance over Uttarapatha was a structural foundation of Pushyabhuti political power before and during Harsha's reign.

Q 105. Ans. A

Explanation:

- The Bharhut stupa in Satna district of modern Madhya Pradesh, dated to the Shunga period around the 2nd century BCE, is the most celebrated ancient site for its elaborately carved stone railings and medallions depicting Jataka stories, the narratives of the Buddha's previous lives.
- The carvings at Bharhut are particularly significant because they are accompanied by identifying inscriptions in Brahmi script that label the scenes, donors, and figures depicted, making them uniquely valuable for both art historical and textual analysis.

- The Bharhut sculptures represent one of the earliest surviving examples of narrative relief art in ancient India, using visual storytelling conventions such as continuous narration, where multiple episodes of a single story appear within one carved panel.
- Most of the surviving Bharhut railing panels and medallions were excavated by Alexander Cunningham in the 1870s and are now housed in the Indian Museum in Kolkata.
- Konark is a medieval Orissan sun temple with erotic and military sculptural programmes unrelated to Jataka narratives.
- Ellora is a rock-cut cave complex with Buddhist, Hindu, and Jain monuments spanning several centuries.
- Pattadakal is a Chalukyan temple site in Karnataka known for its Nagara and Dravida structural temples.

Q 106. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Divyavadana records that Bindusara had a strong personal inclination toward the Ajivika sect and that the Ajivika ascetic Pingalavatsa held a position of religious prominence at his court. This association with the Ajivikas is consistent with the broader pattern of Mauryan rulers extending patronage to multiple heterodox sects simultaneously, a tradition that continued under Ashoka, who later dedicated the Barabar caves to Ajivika monks.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Ancient sources record a well-known diplomatic exchange in which Bindusara wrote to the Seleucid king Antiochus I, requesting three things: sweet wine, dried figs, and a sophist or Greek philosopher. Antiochus replied that he was happy to send the wine and figs but that Greek law did not permit the selling of philosophers. This exchange is one of the most vivid illustrations of the active intellectual and diplomatic contact maintained between the Mauryan court and the Hellenistic world.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Barabar cave excavations were commissioned by Ashoka, not Bindusara. Ashoka dedicated these rock-cut caves to the Ajivika monks in his 12th regnal year, as recorded in the cave inscriptions themselves. Attributing the Barabar caves to

Bindusara directly contradicts this epigraphic evidence.

- **Statement 4 is incorrect:** According to the Divyavadana, the revolt in Taxila during Bindusara's reign was not caused by a Greek invasion. The people of Taxila were unhappy with corrupt and oppressive officials, called dushtamatyas (rogue ministers/administrators). Their dissatisfaction was against bad governance, not foreign attack.

Q 107. Ans. A

Explanation:

- The Manusmriti provides the most explicit and widely cited definition of Aryavarta as the land lying between the Himalayas in the north and the Vindhyas in the south, bounded by the eastern and western seas.
- This definition established Aryavarta as the sacred heartland of Brahmanical civilisation, where the rules of varna, dharma, and ritual purity were considered fully operative.
- The text further stipulated that twice-born men should ideally reside within Aryavarta and learn proper conduct by observing the behaviour of those born and raised within its boundaries.
- The Arthashastra uses the term Aryavarta but does not provide the same precisely bounded geographical definition.
- The Ashtadhyayi of Panini references Aryavarta in a grammatical and cultural context, broadly identifying it with the region of correct Sanskrit usage, while Patanjali's Mahabhashya similarly uses it in a linguistic rather than a strictly territorial sense.

Q 108. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Kumrahar, in present-day Patna, was part of ancient Pataliputra. The most famous discovery here is the remains of an 80-pillared hall from the Mauryan period. Historians believe it was a royal assembly hall where the king and officials held important meetings. It also supports Megasthenes' description of the grand buildings of Pataliputra.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The pillars of this hall were made of polished Chunar sandstone, not

baked terracotta bricks. These stone pillars had the famous Mauryan polish, the same smooth, shining finish seen on the pillars of Ashoka.

- **Statement 3 is correct:** Excavations at Kumrahar also found a Buddhist monastery from the Gupta period called an Arogya Vihara. It shows that some monasteries also worked as places for treatment and medical care.
- **Statement 4 is incorrect:** The 80-pillared hall was not a military camp or cavalry station. Archaeologists consider it an administrative or royal meeting hall, not a place for soldiers or horses.

Q 109. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Mudrarakshasa, a Sanskrit drama by Vishakhadatta, records that Chandragupta formed a crucial military alliance with Parvataka, a Himalayan king, to build the combined military strength needed to defeat the powerful Nanda dynasty of Magadha. This alliance provided Chandragupta with the additional troops and strategic support that made the overthrow of the Nandas militarily viable.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Following Alexander's death in 323 BCE, his Greek and Macedonian garrisons remained stationed in the northwestern regions of the subcontinent. The classical author Justin records that Chandragupta, referred to as Sandroktos, raised an army and systematically expelled these Macedonian garrisons, liberating the northwestern territories from foreign military presence before consolidating his position in Magadha. This campaign formed the early foundation of Mauryan territorial expansion in the northwest.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** It is the Brahmanical Puranic tradition, not Buddhist texts, that associates Chandragupta's lineage with low-born or Shudra origins, describing him variously as the son of a Nanda king by a woman of low status. Buddhist texts, specifically the Mahavamsa and Dipavamsa, take the opposite position and identify Chandragupta as belonging to the Moriya Kshatriya clan from Pipphalivana, deliberately connecting his lineage to the same Kshatriya community as the Buddha himself.

Q 110. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** In Buddhism, Nirvana (or Nibbana in Pali) is the ultimate spiritual goal. It literally translates to “blowing out” or “quenching,” referring to the extinguishing of the fires of attachment (greed), aversion (hatred), and ignorance (delusion). It is a state of profound peace and complete liberation from dukkha (suffering) and the cycle of rebirth (samsara).
- **Statement 2 is Correct:** After attaining enlightenment under the Bodhi tree at Uruvela (Bodhi Gaya), Gautama Buddha travelled to the Deer Park at Sarnath (near Varanasi). There, he delivered his first teaching to his five former ascetic companions. This momentous event in Buddhist history is known as the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (in Pali) or Dharmachakrapravartana (in Sanskrit), which translates to the “Turning of the Wheel of Dharma” (or Law).

Q 111. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Mahabhinishkramana literally translates to the “Great Departure” or the “Great Renunciation.” It refers to the pivotal moment when Prince Siddhartha Gautama, at the age of 29, abandoned his luxurious palace life, his wife Yashodhara, and his newborn son Rahula to become a wandering ascetic.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** This monumental departure was directly motivated by his encounter with the “Four Sights” (an old man, a sick man, a corpse, and an ascetic) during a chariot ride outside the palace. These sights made him realise the universal nature of suffering (dukkha)—aging, disease, and death.

Q 112. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Megasthenes divided the Indian population into seven distinct occupational classes: philosophers, farmers, herdsmen and shepherds, artisans and craftsmen, soldiers, overseers and spies, and councillors and assessors of the king. He observed that these categories were hereditary

and that individuals did not cross from one class into another, which broadly reflected his understanding of the Indian social and occupational order, though his framework did not map precisely onto the varna system.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Megasthenes explicitly recorded the absence of slavery in India, stating that “all Indians are free, and not one of them is a slave.” This observation is widely believed by historians to be a misunderstanding on his part. The form of slavery or bonded labour that existed in ancient India was relatively mild and fundamentally different from the harsh chattel slavery Megasthenes was familiar with in ancient Greece, leading him to conclude it didn’t exist at all.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Megasthenes recorded that all agricultural land in India belonged to the king and that farmers cultivated it as tenants, paying a share of the produce to the royal treasury as rent. This observation aligns broadly with the Arthashastra’s description of state control over land revenue and the king’s fiscal relationship with the cultivating population.

Q 113. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Aparanta, meaning the western end or the western frontier, was the ancient name for the coastal region corresponding broadly to the Konkan coast of present-day Maharashtra and northern Goa. It stretched along the narrow coastal strip between the Western Ghats and the Arabian Sea.
- The region finds mention in Ashokan edicts, where it is listed among the frontier territories where Ashoka’s dhamma missionaries were dispatched, indicating that it lay at the western periphery of the Mauryan imperial zone.
- The Puranas and the Arthashastra also reference Aparanta as a distinct western coastal region.
- During the Mauryan period, the region was significant for its access to western sea trade and its connections with the ports that linked India to the Persian Gulf and the Red Sea commercial networks.
- It was later absorbed into the territories contested by the Satavahanas and the Western Kshatrapas, both of whom valued its coastal commercial position.

Q 114. Ans. B**Explanation:**

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The first Buddhist council was held in Saptaparni cave Rajgir (Rajagriha) in 483 BCE under the patronage of King Ajatashatru shortly after the demise of Lord Buddha (in Kushinara) during the first rainy season. It was imperative to preserve teachings and ideas of Lord Buddha for posterity; there was no relevant technology. Oral tradition was the primary mode of preservation, as religious texts were not yet committed to writing.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The First Buddhist Council was the first well-organised “collective” effort towards preservation of knowledge in its original form for future generations. It contributed immensely in transforming Buddhism into a world religion following Patliputra’s third Council held under Ashoka the Great.

Q 115. Ans. B**Explanation:**

- The terms Udranga, Uparikara, and Vata-bhuta frequently appear in Post-Gupta copper plate land grant inscriptions as specific types of fiscal obligations linked to agricultural land.
- Udranga referred to a form of revenue or tax collected from cultivated land and is generally understood as the main land tax.
- Uparikara referred to additional levies collected over and above the main land revenue. These were extra charges or surcharges imposed on cultivators and landholders.
- Vata-bhuta referred to the obligatory supply of grass, fodder, and firewood that cultivators had to provide to the state. This was a form of

non-monetary tax attached to landholding.

- When kings issued copper plate land grants to Brahmanas, religious institutions, or favoured individuals, these obligations, along with several others, were explicitly listed as exemptions transferred to the donee. This meant that the donee gained the right to collect these dues, which were earlier collected by the state.

Q 116. Ans. A**Explanation:**

- **First Buddhist Council**
 - ✓ The First Buddhist Council was held shortly after the Mahaparinirvana of Gautama Buddha.
 - ✓ It was convened at Rajgir (ancient Rajagriha) under the patronage of King Ajatashatru.
 - ✓ The main objective was to compile and preserve the teachings of the Buddha.
- **Second Buddhist Council**
 - ✓ The Second Buddhist Council took place at Vaishali about 100 years after the Buddha’s death.
 - ✓ It was mainly concerned with disputes regarding monastic discipline and practices among Buddhist monks.
- **Third Buddhist Council**
 - ✓ The Third Buddhist Council was held at Patna (ancient Pataliputra) during the reign of Ashoka.
 - ✓ It aimed to purify the Buddhist Sangha and remove corrupt practices.
- **Fourth Buddhist Council**
 - ✓ The Fourth Buddhist Council was held in Kashmir under the patronage of Kanishka.
 - ✓ It is associated particularly with the development of Mahayana Buddhism.

Council	Year (Approx)	Venue	Patron (King)	Presided By
1st	483 BCE	Rajagriha	Ajatashatru	Mahakashyapa
2nd	383 BCE	Vaishali	Kalasoka	Sabbakami
3rd	250 BCE	Pataliputra	Ashoka	Moggaliputta Tissa
4th	72 AD	Kashmir	Kanishka	Vasumitra

Q 117. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Arthashastra mentions that the king's personal bodyguard was composed of armed women, who were stationed within the royal chambers and accompanied the king as his immediate security detail. Kautilya recommended this arrangement partly because women attendants could access the king's private quarters without suspicion, making them effective as both attendants and security personnel.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Arthashastra describes the use of women disguised as wandering ascetics, known as Bhikshuki agents, as part of the Mauryan espionage network. These women moved freely through society under the cover of religious mendicancy, gathering political intelligence, monitoring the loyalty of officials, and reporting directly to the state. Kautilya's spy system was notable for its systematic use of women in multiple intelligence-gathering roles precisely because their social mobility made them less conspicuous than male agents.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Mauryan state actively employed women in state-run textile workshops, particularly widows, women with physical disabilities, women who had renounced the world, and those in financial distress. These workshops produced textiles for state use and were supervised by the Sutradhyaksha, the superintendent of weaving. Women formed the primary workforce of the state textile production system.

Q 118. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Anga was the ancient Mahajanapada lying to the east of Magadha, and the two kingdoms were separated by the Champa River, which also served as the name of Anga's capital city.
- Anga corresponded broadly to the modern districts of Bhagalpur and Munger in eastern Bihar.
- The Champa river, identified with the modern Chandan river, thus simultaneously functioned as a political boundary between two rival kingdoms and as the namesake of Anga's principal urban centre.

- Anga was a prosperous kingdom due to its fertile agricultural land and its access to riverine and overland trade routes connecting the Gangetic plains with Bengal and the northeastern regions.
- The conflict between Magadha and Anga was a recurring theme in early Buddhist and Jain texts, and the eventual annexation of Anga by Magadha under Bimbisara of the Haryanka dynasty was one of the foundational territorial expansions that set Magadha on the path to imperial dominance over the entire Gangetic plain.

Q 119. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Four Noble Truths contain the essence of the Buddha's teachings. It was these four principles that the Buddha came to understand during his meditation under the bodhi tree.
 - ✓ The truth of suffering (Dukkha)
 - ✓ The truth of the origin of suffering (Samudāya)
 - ✓ The truth of the cessation of suffering (Nirodha)
 - ✓ The truth of the path to the cessation of suffering (Magga)

Q 120. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Dharmaraja Ratha:** The Dharmaraja Ratha at Mahabalipuram is the tallest among the Pancha Rathas and features ascending pyramidal storeys with progressively receding tiers, each decorated with miniature roof forms called haras. It is architecturally recognised as the earliest and most direct prototype for the multi-storeyed vimana form that later Pallava and Chola structural temples fully developed and standardised.
- **Shore Temple:** The Shore Temple at Mahabalipuram was built by Rajasimha (Narasimhavarman II) in the early 8th century CE and represents the transition from monolithic rock-cut to freestanding structural masonry temple construction in Pallava architecture. It is the earliest surviving freestanding stone structural temple of the Pallava period and is a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

- **Draupadi Ratha:** The Draupadi Ratha is the smallest among the Pancha Rathas and is uniquely distinctive for its monolithic roof carved to resemble a curved thatched village hut, technically referred to in architectural literature as a kuta or sala roof form. It reflects the early Pallava practice of replicating vernacular timber and thatch construction forms in permanent stone.
- **Mahendravarman Mandapas:** The rock-cut mandapas attributed to Mahendravarman I at sites including Mandagapattu, Mahendravadi, and Tiruchirapalli represent the earliest phase of Pallava architectural activity. They are excavated directly into natural rock outcrops and consist entirely of pillared halls and shrines without any structural superstructure built above ground level. The Mandagapattu inscription of Mahendravarman I explicitly records his pride in constructing these temples without the use of timber, brick, or metal.

Q 121. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** In Jainism, the term Tirthankara does not refer to a holy place to visit with devotion
 - ✓ The word refers to a spiritual guide or enlightened being who shows humanity the path toward liberation and salvation.
 - ✓ The term "Tirtha" symbolically refers to a crossing point or path that helps individuals move beyond worldly existence.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** A Tirthankara is regarded as a spiritual teacher who guides people toward moksha or liberation.
 - ✓ After attaining enlightenment, Tirthankaras preach the path of right conduct, knowledge, and faith.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Jain texts clearly distinguish between a Kevali and a Tirthankara.
 - ✓ A Kevali is an omniscient being who has attained perfect knowledge.
 - ✓ However, not every Kevali becomes a Tirthankara.
 - ✓ Only those enlightened beings who establish or revive the Jain religious order and guide others are called Tirthankaras.

Q 122. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Kesaria stupa, located in the East Champaran district of Bihar, is recognised by the ASI as the tallest excavated Buddhist stupa in the world, standing at approximately 104 feet after partial excavation, with estimates suggesting it may have originally risen considerably higher.
- The stupa is built on a circular terraced plan with multiple ascending tiers, a structural design that bears resemblance to the Borobudur temple complex in Java, reflecting the shared architectural vocabulary of Buddhist monumental construction across Asia.
- According to Buddhist tradition, the site is associated with the Buddha's last journey toward Kushinagar, where he is said to have distributed his begging bowl to the Licchavis who had followed him, after which they turned back and a stupa was raised to mark the spot.
- Xuanzang visited the site in the 7th century CE and recorded the existence of a large stupa at this location.
- Archaeological layers at the site reveal construction activity spanning multiple periods from the Mauryan through the Gupta and post-Gupta eras, indicating that the stupa was successively enlarged and renovated across several centuries.

Q 123. Ans. A

Explanation:

- The Sangam literary corpus is broadly divided into two major categories based on the nature and length of the texts. The Ettuthokai, meaning the Eight Anthologies, and the Pattupattu, meaning the Ten Idylls, together constitute the Melkanakku, meaning the Eighteen Upper or Major Works.
- These eighteen texts form the core of classical Sangam poetry and contain the bulk of the akam (interior, dealing with love) and puram (exterior, dealing with war, heroism, and death) poetry of the Sangam age.
- The Kilkanakku, meaning the Lower or Minor Works, refers to a separate and later set of didactic texts of which the Tirukkural is the most celebrated example.

- Silappadikaram is one of the two Tamil epics and belongs to a different literary category entirely. Tolkappiyam is the oldest Tamil grammatical treatise and stands outside both the Melkanakku and Kilkanakku classifications as a work of grammar and poetics rather than poetry.

Q 124. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Parshvanatha strongly propagated the principle of Ahimsa (non-violence).
 - ✓ He taught that every living being values life and does not want suffering.
 - ✓ His message — “Savve pana piyauva, savve dukkha padikula” — emphasized compassion and respect for all forms of life.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Jain tradition states that Parshvanatha attained Nirvana at Sammed Shikhar.
 - ✓ He attained liberation after fasting for a month at the age of 100.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Parshvanatha rejected narrow social divisions based on caste or class.
 - ✓ The passage clearly mentions that the religion preached by him was neither confined to Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, nor Shudras.
 - ✓ He promoted a universal and pure religion open to all humanity.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** Parshvanatha gave importance to inner peace, penance, purity of conduct, and harmony with all beings rather than external rituals and pomp.
 - ✓ He taught that true religion exists in the purity of the mind and ethical conduct, not merely in rituals or temple worship.

Q 125. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Vasudeva Kanva was the minister of the last Shunga ruler Devabhuti and assassinated him around 73 BCE, establishing the Kanva dynasty in his place. The Puranas record this transition and identify Vasudeva as the founder of the Kanva line. The circumstances of the assassination, a minister overthrowing

his own monarch, mirror the pattern by which Pushyamitra Shunga had earlier displaced the Mauryas, reflecting a recurring political dynamic in post-Mauryan north India.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Kanva dynasty exercised political authority over Magadha and the surrounding Gangetic heartland, which had formed the core of both Mauryan and Shunga imperial power. They had no association with the eastern maritime coast of Kalinga. Kalinga was a distinct political and geographical region with its own separate dynastic history following Ashoka's conquest.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The last Kanva ruler, Susharman, was overthrown by the Satavahanas, who had been consolidating power in the Deccan during the Kanva period. The Puranas record that Susharman was defeated and killed by the Satavahanas, ending the Kanva dynasty around 28 BCE. This transition marked the effective end of Magadha as the centre of north Indian imperial power and signalled the definitive rise of the Satavahanas as the dominant political force of peninsular India.

Q 126. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Mahavira, also known as Vardhamana, was born in a royal Kshatriya family associated with Vaishali in present-day Bihar. Jain traditions describe him as belonging to a politically influential clan connected with the Vajji confederacy. Vaishali was an important centre of political and religious activity during the 6th century BCE.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Mahavira's father was Siddhartha, the head of the Kshatriya Jnatrika clan, and his mother was Trishala. Some Jain traditions associate their family with the Ikshvaku lineage, which is regarded as an ancient and prestigious royal dynasty in Indian tradition. The Ikshvaku lineage is also connected with several earlier Tirthankaras, including Rishabhanatha, the first Tirthankara of Jainism.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Mahavira was indeed the 24th Tirthankara of Jainism, but he did not succeed Neminatha. The 23rd Tirthankara before Mahavira was Parshvanatha. Neminatha was the 22nd Tirthankara.

Q 127. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** Avanti was one of the most powerful Mahajanapadas of the pre-Mauryan period, centred on two principal cities, Ujjain in the north and Mahishmati in the south, both located in the Malwa region of western Madhya Pradesh. Ujjain remained one of the most important political and commercial cities of ancient India across successive dynasties.
- **Pair 2 is incorrectly matched:** Vatsa was centred on Kaushambi, located near the confluence of the Ganga and Yamuna rivers in the region corresponding to the modern Prayagraj district of Uttar Pradesh, not in Bundelkhand near the southern Vindhyas. Kaushambi was an important urban and commercial centre of the Mahajanapada period and is well attested in both Buddhist texts and archaeological excavations.
- **Pair 3 is correctly matched:** Kosala corresponded to the Awadh region of eastern Uttar Pradesh, with its two principal cities being Ayodhya and Shravasti. It was one of the most powerful Mahajanapadas and a major centre of early Buddhist and Jain religious activity, being closely associated with both the Buddha and Mahavira through their travels and teachings.
- **Pair 4 is correctly matched:** Kashi was centred on the city of Varanasi, corresponding to the present-day Varanasi district of Uttar Pradesh. It was one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities of the ancient world and a major centre of Brahmanical learning, trade, and urban culture throughout the Mahajanapada period.

Q 128. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Following the Mahaparinirvana of the Buddha at Kushinagar, his cremated remains became objects of intense political and religious contention among the rulers and republics of the region.
- According to Buddhist tradition recorded in the Mahapari-nibbana Sutta of the Pali Canon, the ashes were divided into eight equal portions among eight claimants, one of which was the Licchavi republic of Vaishali.
- The Licchavis constructed a stupa over their

portion of the relics, and this is the structure identified with the ancient Vaishali stupa.

- Archaeological excavations conducted by the ASI at the Vaishali stupa site uncovered a relic casket containing ashes, bone fragments, and small grave goods, providing physical corroboration for the textual tradition.
- Vaishali's significance in Buddhist history extends further because it was the city where Buddha delivered his last sermon before his final journey to Kushinagar and where he announced his approaching Mahaparinirvana, making the stupa an exceptionally important pilgrimage site within the Buddhist geographical imagination.

Q 129. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Anekāntavāda, literally the “theory of non-one-sidedness” in Sanskrit, is a characteristically Jain metaphysical and semantic doctrine according to which any real and determinate thing admits of contrary predications.
- For example, a thing is classically said to be both existent and nonexistent; permanent and impermanent; universal and particular; and denotable and undenotable.
- The contradiction that would prima facie result from the application of such contrary pairs is averted by parameterising each term so that it and its negation are not applied in the same way; for example, a thing is existent at one time and place, and nonexistent at another.
- Syadvada: Syadvada means the theory of “maybe” or “in some ways”. It teaches that any statement about an object should be made carefully, because truth can have many sides. So, statements are made using the word Syat meaning “in some ways” or “from one point of view”. This method helps explain the Jain idea of Anekantavada, that reality has many aspects.
- Nayavada: Nayavada means the theory of viewpoints. It says that when we describe something, we usually see only one part or aspect of it, not the whole truth. Each viewpoint (naya) gives partial knowledge. To understand reality fully, many viewpoints must be considered together.

Q 130. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Kanishka convened the Fourth Buddhist Council at Kundalavana in Kashmir, presided over by the scholar Vasumitra, with Ashvaghosha playing a prominent supporting role. The council was attended primarily by scholars of the Sarvastivada school of Buddhism and resulted in the compilation of the Mahavibhasha, a vast encyclopaedic commentary on Sarvastivada Abhidharma literature. This council is not recognised by the Theravada tradition, which does not count it among the canonical Buddhist councils.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Ashvaghosha was one of the most celebrated scholars and poets at Kanishka's court. He composed the Buddhacharita, a Sanskrit mahakavya narrating the life of the Buddha from his birth to his enlightenment, and the Saundarananda, another Sanskrit kavya dealing with the conversion of Nanda to Buddhism. Ashvaghosha is also considered an important figure in the development of Sanskrit literary aesthetics and early Mahayana Buddhist philosophy.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Kushana court and the Fourth Buddhist Council under Kanishka used Sanskrit, not Pali, as the language of Buddhist scholarship and debate. The Sarvastivada school patronised by Kanishka operated entirely within the Sanskrit literary and philosophical tradition. Pali was the scriptural language of the Theravada school, which was geographically and doctrinally distinct from the Mahayana and Sarvastivada traditions flourishing under Kushana patronage.

Q 131. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Satavahanas issued some of the earliest known land grant records in Indian history, in which tax-free villages were donated to Brahmanas. These grants are important because they represent the early beginnings of a practice that later became a standard feature of Gupta and post-Gupta administration.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Satavahana land grants included a specific clause that barred state

officials from entering the donated land. This meant the grantee had full control over the land without any interference from the king's officers. This provision is an early form of what later inscriptions would call fiscal and administrative immunity, a feature that became far more elaborate in Gupta-period land charters.

- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Satavahanas did not use gold coins. Their currency consisted mainly of lead, copper, and potin coins. Lead coinage is, in fact, a defining characteristic of Satavahana monetary practice and sets them apart from other contemporary dynasties. Gold coins were largely absent from their monetary system.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** Rural administration under the Satavahanas was handled by military officers called Gaulmikas, who commanded a standard military unit called a gaulma. Placing military officers in charge of rural areas shows that Satavahana governance relied heavily on military control for maintaining order and authority in the countryside.

Q 132. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Goshala Maskariputra, also known as Gosala Makkhaliputta, was the founder of the Ajivika sect. He is traditionally regarded as a contemporary and former associate of Mahavira.
- According to Jain traditions, Gosala lived with Mahavira for several years before separating due to doctrinal differences. The Ajivikas later emerged as an independent ascetic sect alongside Buddhism and Jainism.

Q 133. Ans. B

Explanation:

In Jainism, Tirthankaras are spiritually enlightened beings who show the path to liberation. Several honorific titles are associated with them:

- Arhat
 - ✓ A Tirthankara is called an Arhat, meaning a worthy or venerable enlightened being.
- Veetrag
 - ✓ The term means one who is free from attachment and passions. Tirthankaras are considered completely detached from worldly desires.
- Sarvajna

- ✓ Tirthankaras are regarded as omniscient beings possessing perfect knowledge after attaining Kevala Jnana.

● Chakravartin

- ✓ A Chakravartin refers to a universal emperor or ideal worldly ruler, not a spiritual title specifically associated with Tirthankaras.

Q 134. Ans. A

Explanation:

- The Nitisara, composed by Kamandaka around the 7th-8th century CE, is a treatise on statecraft and political philosophy written in verse form. It is explicitly modelled on Kautilya's Arthashastra and draws heavily from it, making it essentially a poetic reworking of Arthashastra principles for a post-Gupta political audience.
- The text covers the seven elements of the state (Saptanga theory), the duties of the king, the conduct of diplomacy through the fourfold policy of sama, dana, danda, and bheda, the use of espionage networks, and the theory of the Mandala or circle of states governing interstate relations. Unlike the Arthashastra's dense technical prose, the Nitisara presents these political ideas in accessible Sanskrit verse, making it a widely cited political reference in medieval Indian courts. It is an important source for understanding how Kautilyan political thought was transmitted, adapted, and popularised in the early medieval period.

Q 135. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** According to the Ajivikas, everything in the universe operates according to an unchangeable cosmic law called Niyati. Human life, suffering, happiness, and liberation were all predetermined. Makkhali Gosala, philosopher and initiator of "Niyativada" doctrine and "Ajivika" sect deemed that all endeavours to bring change in one's life are doomed to be futile and any attempt to escape the inevitable has to end in failure.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Ajivikas rejected the idea that human effort or karma could significantly change destiny. This distinguished them from Jainism and Buddhism, both of which emphasised individual action and moral effort.

Q 136. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The statement "All men are my children" appears in the First Separate Rock Edict, found at Dhauli in Odisha and Jaugada in Odisha. These edicts are also called the Kalinga Edicts because they were issued specifically for the newly conquered Kalinga region and are found only at these two sites, unlike the Major Rock Edicts, which were distributed across the empire.
- In this edict, Ashoka addresses his judicial officers directly and instructs them to govern the people of Kalinga with the same care, impartiality, and affection that a father extends to his children.
- The deliberate placement of this edict at Dhauli, the very site associated with the brutal Kalinga war that transformed Ashoka's political philosophy, makes its message of paternal kingship and dhamma governance particularly significant.
- The Bhabru edict at Bairat records Ashoka's personal faith in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha and lists specific Buddhist texts he recommends.
- Major Rock Edict XIII at Shahbazgarhi records Ashoka's remorse over the Kalinga war and his adoption of dhamma conquest over military conquest.
- The Rummindei Pillar Inscription records Ashoka's pilgrimage to Lumbini and grants the village tax exemptions in honour of the Buddha's birthplace.

Q 137. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Karna Chaupar Cave is one of the four famous caves located in the Barabar Hills of Bihar. It belongs to the Mauryan period and contains inscriptions associated with Emperor Ashoka.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Viswakarma Cave is also part of the Barabar cave group. Like the other caves of the complex, it reflects the earliest tradition of Indian rock-cut architecture and is associated with Mauryan patronage.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Sudama Cave is among the best-known caves of the Barabar Hills. It bears an inscription in Prakrit language and Brahmi script mentioning Ashoka (Priyadarshin). The cave was dedicated to the Ajivikas.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** Lomas Rishi Cave is

another important cave of the Barabar group. It is especially famous for its decorative chaitya-arch entrance and is considered highly significant from an artistic point of view.

Q 138. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** The Harshacharita is Banabhatta's celebrated Sanskrit prose biography of Emperor Harsha, covering his ancestry, early life, and rise to power. It is the foundational text of the Akhyayika prose genre in Sanskrit literature and is the primary literary source for reconstructing Harsha's political career.
- **Pair 2 is incorrectly matched:** Kadambari is not a grammatical text. It is a lengthy Sanskrit prose romance and is considered the world's earliest novel by some scholars. It narrates a complex multi-life love story involving the characters Kadambari and Chandrapida. Banabhatta left it incomplete, and it was finished by his son Bhushanabhatta.
- **Pair 3 is correctly matched:** Parvati Parinaya is a short Sanskrit work by Banabhatta describing the divine marriage of Shiva and Parvati. It belongs to the devotional literary tradition and demonstrates Banabhatta's range across biographical, romantic, and religious literary genres.
- **Pair 4 is incorrectly matched:** Chandi Shataka is a devotional hymn of one hundred verses addressed to the goddess Chandi, an aspect of Durga. It has no connection to temple architecture or Nagara construction rules whatsoever.

Q 139. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Ghosha was a Brahnavadini, meaning a woman who dedicated herself to Vedic learning and spiritual discourse rather than domestic life through marriage. She is credited with composing two complete hymns in the Rigveda, specifically hymns 39 and 40 of the tenth Mandala.
- This makes her one of the approximately 27 women composers, collectively called Brahnavadinis, whose compositions found a permanent place in the Rigvedic corpus alongside those of male rishis. Ghosha belonged to the lineage of the rishi Kakshivat and, according to tradition, suffered from a

skin disease called kushtha, from which she was believed to have been cured through her devotion to the Ashvins, the divine twin physicians of the Vedic pantheon.

- Her hymns in the tenth Mandala are addressed primarily to the Ashvins and reflect both personal supplication and philosophical depth.
- Her inclusion in the Rigveda is significant evidence that women in the early Vedic period were not excluded from the highest levels of religious and intellectual life, a status that progressively deteriorated in the later Vedic and post-Vedic periods as orthodoxy tightened restrictions on women's participation in sacrificial and scholarly traditions.

Q 140. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct.** Vadathi-ka-Kubha is one of the three caves located in the Nagarjuni Hills near Gaya in Bihar. These caves are part of the rock-cut architectural tradition associated with the Mauryan period and were later patronised by Dasaratha, the grandson of Ashoka.
- **Statement 2 is correct.** Vapiya-ka-Kubha is also part of the Nagarjuni cave group. It is named after a well ("vapiya") located nearby, which gives it its alternative designation as the "cave of the well." The cave is associated with inscriptions mentioning its dedication to the Ajivikas by Dasaratha.
- **Statement 3 is correct.** Gopi-ka-Kubha is the most prominent cave in the Nagarjuni Hills group. It has the largest chamber among the three caves and contains Mauryan polished surfaces along with important inscriptions. These inscriptions indicate its dedication to the Ajivika sect by Dasaratha shortly after his consecration.

Q 141. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Charvaka was a heterodox Indian philosophy known for its materialism and atheism. It rejected the Vedas, karma, rebirth, moksha, and the existence of an immortal soul. Charvakas accepted only direct perception (pratyaksha) as a valid source of knowledge, shaping a worldview based purely on empirical experience and rejecting religious or supernatural beliefs.

Q 142. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Dakshinamurti literally translates to “one who is facing south” (dakshina means south). In this form, Lord Shiva is revered as the supreme cosmic teacher (Guru) of yoga, music, wisdom, and the exposition of the shastras. He is typically depicted sitting under a banyan tree, facing south, often surrounded by sages receiving his silent instruction. The south direction is traditionally associated with death and change, and Shiva facing it signifies his mastery over them.

Q 143. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is true:** The Minor Rock Edicts are among the most personally revealing of all Ashokan records. Unlike the Major Rock Edicts, which are largely policy and dhamma proclamations directed outward at subjects and officials, the Minor Rock Edicts contain direct first-person statements by Ashoka about his own religious convictions, making them primary sources for understanding his personal spiritual life.
- **Reason (R) is true and correctly explains (A):** The Bhabru Minor Rock Edict at Bairat explicitly states that Ashoka had been a lay Buddhist follower for more than two and a half years but had not been particularly zealous during that period. It then records that after associating more closely with the Sangha, his religious commitment deepened significantly. This self-description of moving from a passive lay follower to an actively engaged supporter of the Sangha is precisely what makes the Minor Rock Edicts uniquely valuable for reconstructing Ashoka's personal religious journey.

Q 144. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Medhatithi, a well-known commentator on the Manusmriti, strongly upheld the authority of the Vedas and rejected religious systems that did not conform to Vedic injunctions. He did not accept Buddhism, Jainism, the Pancaratra (Bhagavata tradition), or the Pasupata sect as valid expressions of dharma because they were outside Vedic authority.

Q 145. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The Anguttara Nikaya, a major Buddhist scripture and the fourth of the five Nikayas in the Sutta Pitaka, provides the most prominent and frequently cited list of the sixteen great kingdoms or republics (Solasa Mahajanapadas) that flourished in the Indian subcontinent around the 6th century BCE.
- Anguttara Nikaya: This text explicitly names the 16 Mahajanapadas: Kasi, Kosala, Anga, Magadha, Vajji, Malla, Chedi, Vatsa, Kuru, Panchala, Matsya, Surasena, Assaka, Avanti, Gandhara, and Kamboja. (Note for your studies: The Jain text Bhagavati Sutra also provides a list of sixteen Mahajanapadas, though the names vary slightly from the Buddhist list)

Q 146. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Amatya:** Amatya refers to the high-ranking ministers and senior bureaucratic officials responsible for managing the day-to-day administration of the state. The Arthashastra devotes considerable attention to the recruitment, testing, and supervision of Amatyas, as the quality of the bureaucracy was considered directly linked to the effectiveness of royal governance.
- **Janapada:** Janapada refers to the physical territory of the kingdom along with its settled population of cultivators and taxpayers. The Arthashastra emphasises that a well-populated and agriculturally productive Janapada is the material foundation of state power, since land revenue extracted from the cultivating population formed the primary source of the royal treasury.
- **Danda:** Danda literally means the rod or force of punishment and refers to the military and coercive apparatus of the state. It encompasses the army, the enforcement of law, and the maintenance of internal order and external defence. The concept of Dandaniti, the science of wielding force, is central to the entire political philosophy of the Arthashastra.
- **Mitra:** Mitra refers to the ally, specifically a sovereign ruler or neighbouring state that provides diplomatic support, military assistance, or strategic backing to the king. The

Arthashastra's Mandala theory of interstate relations places the Mitra within a complex web of natural friends, enemies, and neutrals surrounding any given kingdom.

Q 147. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Champa (located near modern-day Bhagalpur, Bihar) was the ancient capital of the Anga Mahajanapada. Archaeological excavations at this site have yielded extensive and significant evidence of Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW), firmly associating the city with the "Second Urbanisation" of the Gangetic Valley (c. 6th century BCE onwards).

Q 148. Ans. D

Explanation:

The Vajji (or Vriji) Mahajanapada was a powerful republican confederacy (Gana-sangha) rather than a monarchy. It was comprised of eight distinct clans (known as the atthakula).

- **Licchavis:** The Licchavis were the most powerful and prominent clan within the Vajji confederacy. Their capital, Vaishali, was a major political and commercial hub and also served as the central headquarters for the entire confederacy.
- **Videhas:** The Videhas were a major clan of the confederacy, with their renowned capital at Mithila. According to ancient texts, they were originally a monarchy (prominently associated with King Janaka) but later transitioned into a republican system and joined the Vajji alliance.
- **Jnatikas:** The Jnatikas were a highly significant clan based in Kundagrama (a suburb of Vaishali). Vardhamana Mahavira, the 24th Tirthankara of Jainism, was born into the royal family of this clan. They were an integral member of the Vajji confederacy.
- **Shakyas:** The Shakyas were an independent, sovereign republican clan with their capital at Kapilavastu (located in the Himalayan foothills near the modern India-Nepal border). They are famous as the clan into which Gautama Buddha was born, but they were entirely separate from and not a part of the Vajji confederacy.

Q 149. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** The Rajatarangini, meaning River of Kings, was composed by Kalhana in the 12th century CE and is the chronicle of the kings of Kashmir. It is the most sophisticated example of historical writing in Sanskrit literature and is notable for its critical approach to sources, making it a foundational text in the study of early Indian historiography.
- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** The Dipavamsa, meaning Chronicle of the Island, is a Pali text from Sri Lanka and is considered the oldest surviving chronicle of the island's history. It records the arrival of Buddhism in Sri Lanka, the Mauryan connection through Ashoka's son Mahinda, and the dynastic history of the early Sinhalese kings.
- **Pair 3 is correctly matched:** The Mushika Vamsha was composed by the Sanskrit poet Atula and chronicles the history of the Mushika dynasty, a ruling lineage of northern Kerala. It is an important regional chronicle for reconstructing early medieval Kerala history and stands as one of the few surviving dynastic chronicles from the Kerala region.
- **Pair 4 is incorrectly matched:** The Vikramankadevacharita was composed by the Kashmiri poet Bilhana and celebrates the life and achievements of Vikramaditya VI, the Western Chalukya king of Kalyani in the Deccan, not any ruler of Kamarupa. Kamarupa was a distinct kingdom in present-day Assam with no connection to this text.

Q 150. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The Mallas were one of the sixteen Mahajanapadas (great realms) of ancient India. Unlike kingdoms such as Magadha that were ruled by a single hereditary monarch, the Malla state operated as a Gana-Sangha (an oligarchic republic). Their political system was characterised by a ruling assembly consisting of multiple clan chiefs or representatives who collectively governed the territory.

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